Community Experience Distilled

bbPress Complete

A comprehensive guide to bbPress with clear and concise instructions on expanding your WordPress site with a community forum

Rhys Wynne

[PACKT] PUBLISHING open source* community experience distilled

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Apart from Internet technologies, Rhys is a keen football fan, supporting his hometown team of Colwyn Bay, and he also enjoys traveling and photography.

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Thanks to Hannah and my family in Wales for dealing with all my late nights and my 'geeky' hobby over the years.

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Preface

bbPress Complete is a comprehensive guide to bbPress, a forum management plugin for WordPress. This book will help you in creating, managing, and growing forums, as well as expanding bbPress' functionality and integrating it with your current WordPress site.

What this book covers

Chapter 1, *Getting Started with bbPress*, discusses the history of WordPress and bbPress and how to install bbPress as well as troubleshoot common installation problems. You will finish this chapter and log into your forum for the first time.

Chapter 2, *Taking Your First Steps with bbPress*, discusses how to set up both WordPress and bbPress so that your forums display them as you want. We will also learn how to create, modify, and delete posts and forums.

Chapter 3, *User Management in bbPress*, covers how to create and modify your user profile as well as manage other users on your forum. There will also be an overview of user roles on the forum as well.

Chapter 4, *Extending bbPress Using Plugins*, covers how to expand bbPress' functionality with a selection of plugins for bbPress and WordPress. Topics covered in this chapter include a guide on setting these plugins up as well as questions to ask yourself before installing new plugins and before finishing off with a guide to common bbPress functions, so that you can begin coding on your own.

Chapter 5, *Adding bbPress to Your WordPress Theme*, covers how to integrate bbPress into your WordPress theme via the widgets and menu functions. Also, we will cover making your template bbPress ready using the WordPress' templating system as well as creating a forum-specific sidebar.

What you need for this book

For this book you simply need WordPress installed and working ideally on a Linux server, though you can have it set up on a local machine connected to the Internet.

Who this book is for

This book is aimed at anyone who wishes to set up a forum on their site. Ideally, they will be familiar with WordPress, but it's not necessary.

For some of the more advanced topics discussed later in the book, a working knowledge of PHP, HTML, and CSS is desirable as well as confidence in using FTP.

Conventions

In this book, you will find a number of styles of text that distinguish between different kinds of information. Here are some examples of these styles, and an explanation of their meaning.

Code words in text are shown as follows: " Select the `bbpress` folder, and then right-click to delete it."

New terms and **important words** are shown in bold. Words that you see on the screen, in menus or dialog boxes for example, appear in the text like this: "Select **Delete all posts**, and then click on **Confirm Deletion**."

Warnings or important notes appear in a box like this.

Tips and tricks appear like this.

A block of code is set as follows:

```
'name' => __( 'Forum Sidebar', 'bbpress' ),
'id' => 'sidebar-forum',
'before_widget' => '<aside id="%1$s" class="widget %2$s">',
```

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1
Getting Started with bbPress

bbPress, which is a popular forum management plugin for WordPress, is relatively simple to install and run. However, if you are not familiar with the WordPress installation environment, it could be a bit daunting. This chapter will serve as an introduction to bbPress and will guide you through the installation of bbPress onto your WordPress-based website.

By the end of the chapter, you will have an understanding of bbPress and will have learned the following:

- What bbPress is, its history, and why it is popular
- The prerequisites for installing it—what you need to have on your website before installing bbPress
- How to install bbPress
- How to log in to the administration area of bbPress

What is bbPress?

bbPress is a template-driven forum management plugin built to be used with WordPress. It is designed to be a light plugin, with additional features being added through extensions known as plugins should you want more functionality.

Forums have been around for almost as long as the Internet and are a great way for people with similar interests to connect over the Internet. Examples of the types of sites that can benefit from a forum include:

- Community websites such as local news portals, where members can discuss pressing issues
- Computer software that requires an area to provide technical support

- Clubs, such as sport clubs or youth clubs
- Educational websites, where students can get extracurricular support

Forums can be a lot of work to get started but can eventually become a valuable asset to your website and often will drive a lot of traffic to it. Furthermore, forums can also be a great asset to your online presence, building a community around your services.

A brief history of bbPress

bbPress was created when the co-founder of WordPress, *Matt Mullenweg*, was frustrated with the forum management software that ran the official WordPress support forums after a hosting upgrade broke them. Due to this, a WordPress-based forum software was proposed and coded. On December 28, 2004, new forum software was rolled out to the official WordPress support forum; this was later released as bbPress v0.7.2.

Originally, for most of its development, bbPress was a standalone piece of software with its own database tables and was a fork (making a copy of the code and starting independent development on it) of WordPress's source code. This meant that it was relatively stable, but as bugs were discovered in WordPress, it became harder to maintain. With the release of bbPress 2.0 on September 12, 2011, a decision was made, that bbPress 2.0 would change from being a standalone piece of software to a plugin for WordPress. This generated a few problems; one in particular was that many plugins were designed with early versions of bbPress, and are now incompatible with bbPress 2.0 and many others are no longer maintained. However, an entire library of WordPress plugins was now available from within WordPress.

Today, the project is maintained by the bbPress community and owned by the WordPress Foundation, a charitable organization founded to maintain the interests of open source software. Ownership of the project was given to the WordPress Foundation by Automattic, a commercial development firm, on September 9, 2010.

Benefits of using bbPress

There are many pieces of software that can manage forums, so why should you pick bbPress? Many reasons exist, but here are a few of the key reasons:

- It is **free**, meaning you never have to pay a penny to use the software.
- It is **open source**, meaning that all code associated with the software is available for you to download and modify.
- It is a **community project**, rather than having a small team of developers working on the project, a large number of people can be working on it, from commercial developers to hobby programmers.

- It is **light**. Out of the box, it can be seen to be lacking features, but it has relatively little code to run the forum, which makes it faster and more secure than many of its competitors.
- It is **extensible**. There are over 100 dedicated bbPress plugins currently released adding functionality to your site. Furthermore, many WordPress plugins are also compatible with bbPress.
- It is **modular**. When you install bbPress, it creates all the pages you need, meaning you're ready to run your forum straight away. However, if you decide you don't want to run a bbPress forum anymore, deleting the plugin will not break the rest of your site.
- It **runs on WordPress**, which means that if you use WordPress to run your website, your site will have a familiar look, as coding templates and plugins in bbPress are very similar.

If you wish to see examples of what you can create in bbPress, bbPress keeps examples of quality, active forums that run on their software on their site. You can see this list at `http://bbpress.org/about/examples/`.

Have you decided to use bbPress then? Great! Let's get started!

Prerequisites for installing bbPress

At the time of writing in March 2013, bbPress 2.2.4 requires a Linux server with the following to run:

- PHP Version 5.2.4 or higher
- MySQL Version 5.0 or higher

It is also recommended that a server has Apache with mod_rewrite installed; however, this is not a necessity. Don't worry too much about these requirements as an e-mail to your web host, or any potential web host should give you this information. However, many Linux-based web hosts run these services as standard.

At the time of writing, the requirements for bbPress are exactly the same as WordPress, so if you are running the latest version of WordPress, you can run bbPress.

Installing WordPress

The final prerequisite for bbPress is WordPress. As bbPress is a plugin of WordPress, you need to have WordPress installed and running on your server before activating bbPress.

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This book assumes you already have WordPress installed; however, if you haven't gone through WordPress's *Famous 5-Minute Install* article, which you can read at `http://codex.wordpress.org/Installing_WordPress`.

Many hosts provide a one-click installation service for WordPress. I would recommend that you do not go through this process. Often, the versions of WordPress on this service are one or two versions older than the current version, leaving you open to possible security exploits.

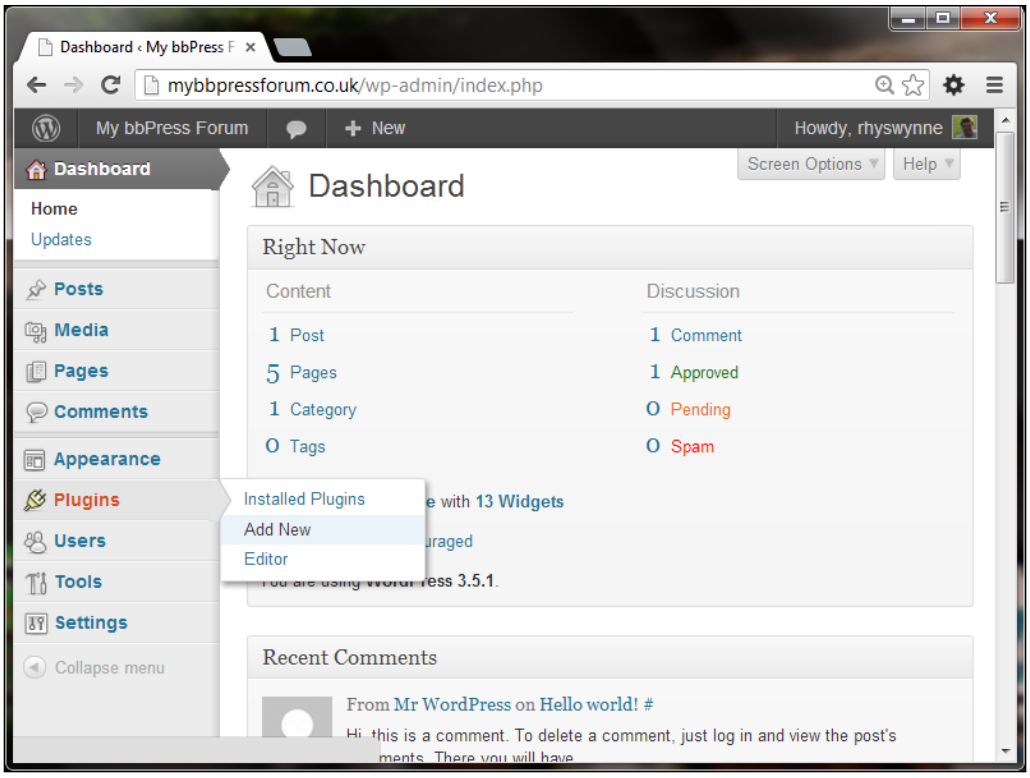
Installing bbPress

As bbPress is a WordPress plugin, we will need to install it like a plugin. Thankfully, this is relatively straightforward and there are three ways to install plugins, which are described as follows:

Method 1 – downloading and installing the plugin from the WordPress repository

The following are the steps to be performed for downloading and installing the plugin from the WordPress repository:

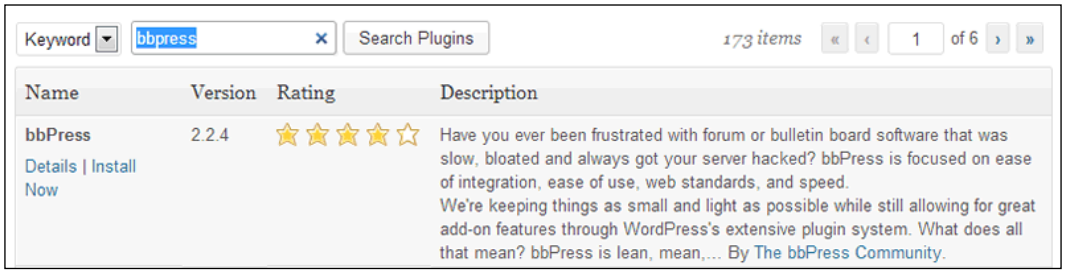
1. In your WordPress installation, visit your login page, which will look similar to `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/wp-admin/`. Log in with your username and password, and you will be taken to the WordPress Dashboard.



On the **Dashboard** screen, down the left-hand side, you should see a menu titled **Plugins**. If you hover over **Plugins**, a pop-up menu should appear, with one of the options being **Add New**. Click on this option.

You will be taken to a screen that has a search box. This will allow you to search the WordPress plugin repository for any plugin that is present within it. As bbPress is a WordPress plugin, we can find bbPress using this method. Type in `bbPress` and click on the **Search Plugins** button.

From here, you should see a list of plugins returned in the search for `bbPress`. One will be the proper **bbPress** plugin. It should be fairly obvious; however, it looks similar to the following screenshot:

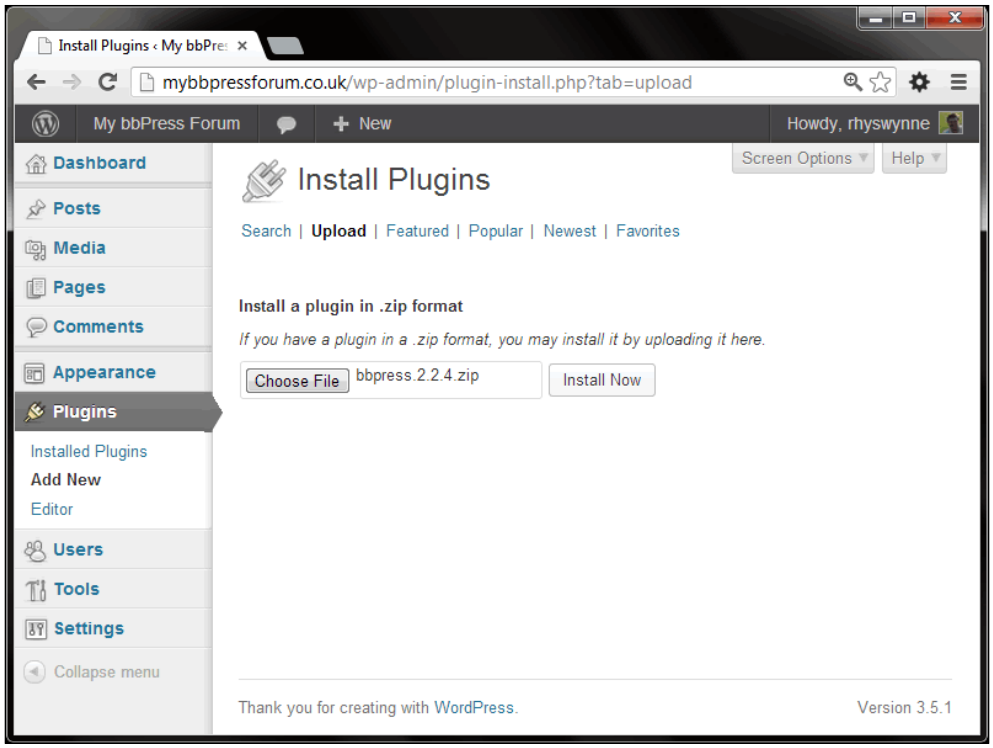


2. If the plugin name is **bbPress**, and its author is **The bbPress Community**, you have found the correct plugin! Click on the **Install Now** link beneath the plugin name, and the plugin will be installed.
3. If the installation is successful, you will be given two options: **Activate Plugin** and **Return to Plugin Installer**.
4. If you click on **Activate Plugin**, the plugin will be activated.
5. Alternatively, if you click on **Return to Plugin Installer**, you'll be taken back to the Plugin Installation Screen. From here, click on **Plugins** in the left-hand menu, search for **bbPress** in the list, and click on **Activate** to activate **bbPress**.

Method 2 – uploading a ZIP file of bbPress to WordPress

The following are the steps to be performed while uploading a ZIP file of bbPress to WordPress:

1. Visit the URL `http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/bbpress/` and click on the **download** button; you will download the latest version of **bbPress**, which you should save to an easy-to-find location, such as the desktop.
2. Then, log in to your WordPress administration site, and in the left navigation hover over **Plugins** and select **Add New**; you should be taken to the **Add New Plugins** screen. Along the top, you should see a link called **Upload**; click on this, and you're taken to the upload screen shown in the following screenshot:



3. Click on **Choose File**, and then navigate to where you saved the `bbPress.zip` file. Make sure the ZIP file's name is in the box (as seen in the preceding screenshot), and then click on **Install Now**. If successful, you will be given the choice to activate the plugin as described previously.

Method 3 – uploading the unzipped bbPress plugin via FTP

This method is the trickiest, and it will be well worth trying it at least once so you're familiar with the installation process.

Before beginning with this installation method, you'll need the following:

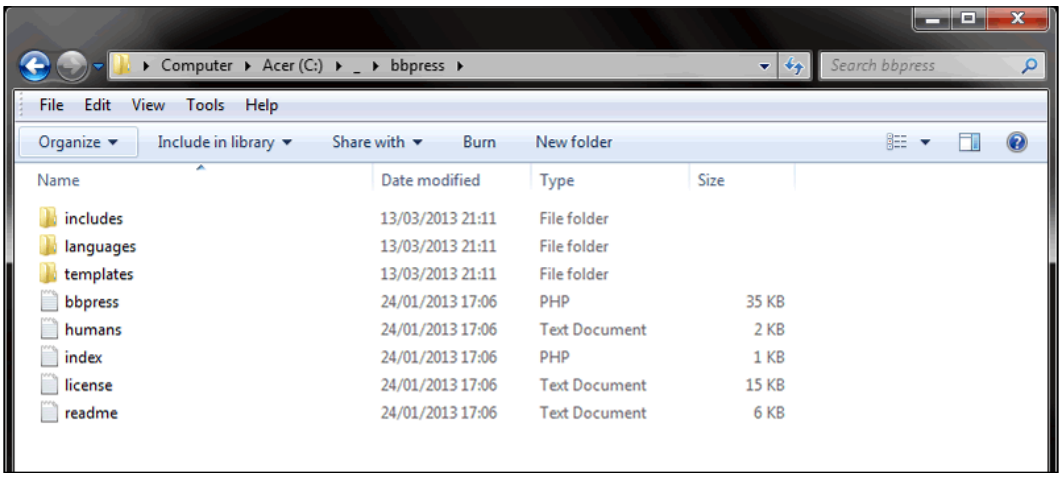
- A **file transfer protocol (FTP)** program such as FileZilla, available to download for free at `http://filezilla-project.org/`.
- The FTP address for your website
- Your FTP username
- Your FTP password

You should have received these details when you signed up for your hosting package; however, if you don't have them, speak to your host and they will provide these details.

The following are the steps to be performed while uploading the unzipped bbPress plugin via FTP:

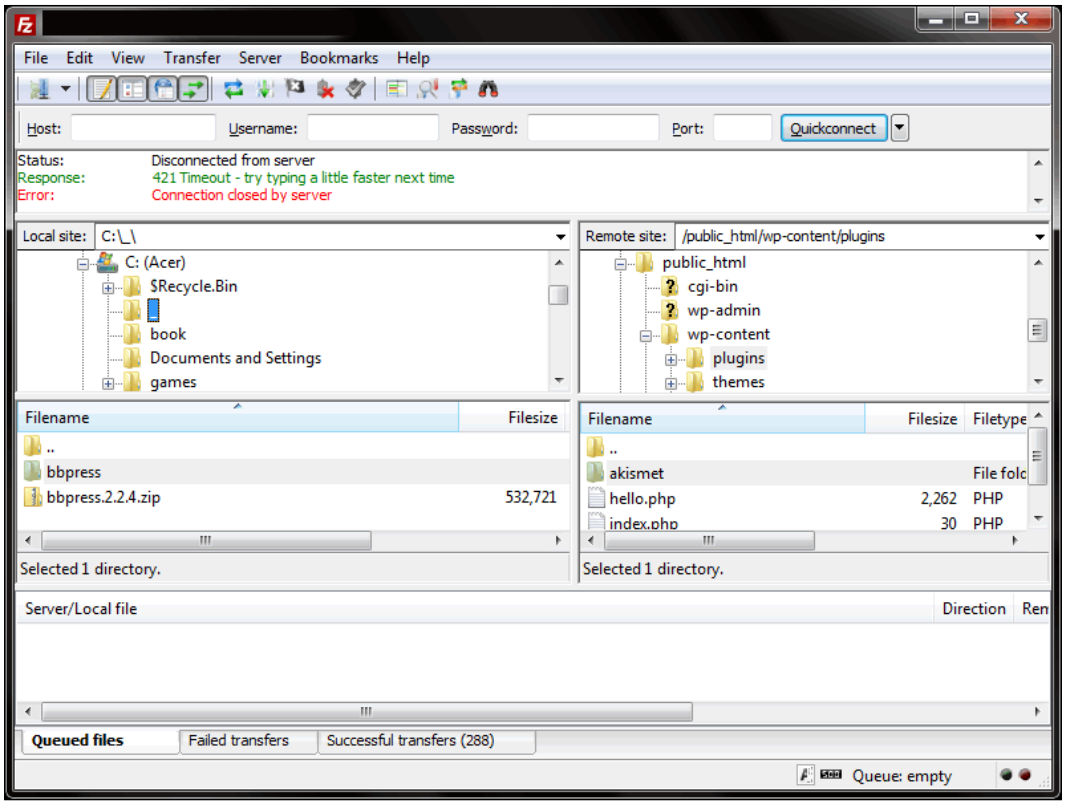
1. Visit the **bbpress** plugin URL, `http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/bbpress/` and download it to an easy-to-find location.
2. Head to that location and find the `bbpress.zip` file.
3. Extract these files to a folder named `bbpress`.

   You should have a folder now with the following files inside it:



4. Download and install FileZilla.

   When you open Filezilla, you should be presented with a screen similar to this:



5. In the **Host** textbox, type in the FTP address for your website.
6. In the **Username** and **Password** fields, type in your FTP username and FTP password, respectively.
7. Ignore the **Port** field and click on **Quickconnect**.
8. In the left window of the screen will be the files on your computer (**Local site**), and on the right-hand side will be your server navigation (**Remote Site**).
9. In the **Local site** window, navigate to the folder that contains the `bbPress` folder, which you extracted earlier. When found, navigate to the `plugins` folder in the **Remote site** window. This will be located in the `wp-content` folder, which will be in the folder where WordPress is installed.
10. Drag the `bbPress` folder into the `plugins` folder, and when fully copied over, log in to your WordPress Dashboard and click on the **Plugins** page. If **bbPress** is listed among the plugins, click to activate it.

If you notice three more menus appearing in the sidebar—**Forums**, **Topics**, and **Replies**, congratulations, your installation of bbPress was successful!

Troubleshooting installation problems

Installations should go fine, but nothing is perfect. Here are a few common installation problems and the solutions for them:

- **There isn't a menu titled Plugins!**

  If you don't have a menu titled **Plugins**, your account with which you log in to WordPress isn't the administrator of your site. There will be a login with the level "administrator", every WordPress site requires one. Speak to anybody who could have had access to your site, for example designers, as to what the administrator login could be.

- **Dialog box asking FTP details on clicking Install Now?**

  Depending on how your host has set up your server, you may not have the ability to install plugins over **hypertext transfer protocol** (**HTTP**), which is the method of installation that WordPress uses to install plugins. However, it does have a backup method, which requires you to authorize WordPress to install the plugin on your behalf. To do this, you will need three pieces of information:

  - The FTP address for your website
  - Your FTP username
  - Your FTP password

  All of that you can obtain from your host. Repeat the installation process, and then type in your FTP address, username and password into the relevant textboxes, and the installation should continue as normal.

- **White screen on installing and activating the plugin, and the site doesn't work. Help!**

  Most of the time when installing plugins, there aren't any issues. However, there are occasionally conflicts that occur. For security reasons, WordPress usually hides these conflicts but displays a blank white page instead. The only way to fix this is to log in to your server through FTP and delete the **bbPress** plugin, which will automatically remove it from the site. To do this, perform the following steps:

  1. Log on to your FTP server (as described in the *Method 3 – uploading the unzipped bbPress plugin via FTP* section) and navigate to the `/wp-content/plugins/` folder.
  2. Select the `bbpress` folder and right-click to delete it. Then, return to your WordPress administration page and go to the **Plugins** page.

You should see the following message appear in red:

> The plugin `bbpress/bbpress.php` has been **deactivated** due to an error: Plugin file does not exist.

You will have to reinstall **bbPress**, but before activating the plugin, deactivate all other plugins that you have running on the site. One by one, activate each plugin until you activate the one that breaks your site again. This will be the plugin that is conflicting with your site; either find a fix or find a replacement for that plugin.

- **My question wasn't answered here**: Luckily, there is a dedicated bbPress forum available, where people can answer questions to issues you are having. Many people volunteer to provide help on these forums. You can visit them at `http://bbpress.org/forums/`.

Summary

Congratulations! You have taken the first step in activating your bbPress forum. By now, you should have an idea of the benefits of using bbPress to run your forum along WordPress. You should also be competent in installing bbPress on any WordPress installation. It may be confusing for the first time, but the more number of installations you do, the easier it gets. You can also spot common issues that could be affecting your site.

In the next chapter, we will look into setting up forums for you, encouraging people to register, and how to create, edit, or delete posts.

2
Taking Your First Steps with bbPress

Congratulations! You have now successfully installed bbPress. If it was complicated to begin with, do not worry. It will eventually become easier for you as you continue installing and working on bbPress. Now let's get on to the fun stuff.

This chapter will give you the basics on how to set up a forum on bbPress, so that by the end of this chapter you will have a forum to share with your community.

This chapter will therefore cover the following:

- Settings in WordPress to get your forums displayed
- The bbPress settings page
- How to create, modify, and delete a forum
- How to create, modify, and delete posts

Setting up WordPress correctly

Before beginning to set up bbPress, you need to make sure that two of the settings for your site are correct. These, while not essential, do assist you in the running of a bbPress forum. These settings will allow visitors to find your site more easily in search engines, navigate through your site more easily, and also actually register for the site.

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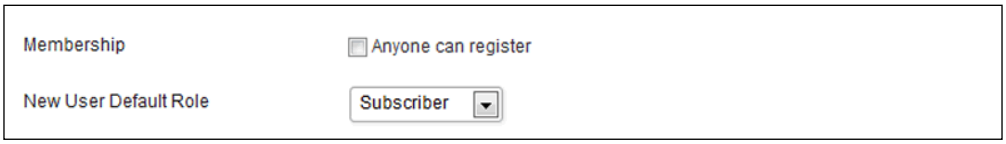
Allowing user registration in WordPress

By default, user registration in WordPress is turned off. This is to prevent spam bots from registering on your site, which could lead to them commenting on your site and writing posts you wouldn't approve of. However, if you want the users to register on your site and post on your forum like on most forums, please do the following:

First of all, in your WordPress Administration at `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/wp-admin/`, click on **Settings**. Halfway down the page, you should see the following two options:



You will want to tick the checkbox allowing anybody to register and set the **New User Default Role** option to **Subscriber.** This applies only to the blog, so that they cannot write posts on your blog. We will set them up on the forum later. Click on **Save Changes** to save the changes.

> If you are worried about spam, please don't be! We will discuss ways of preventing spam in a later chapter, which will allow genuine users to post and block spammers.

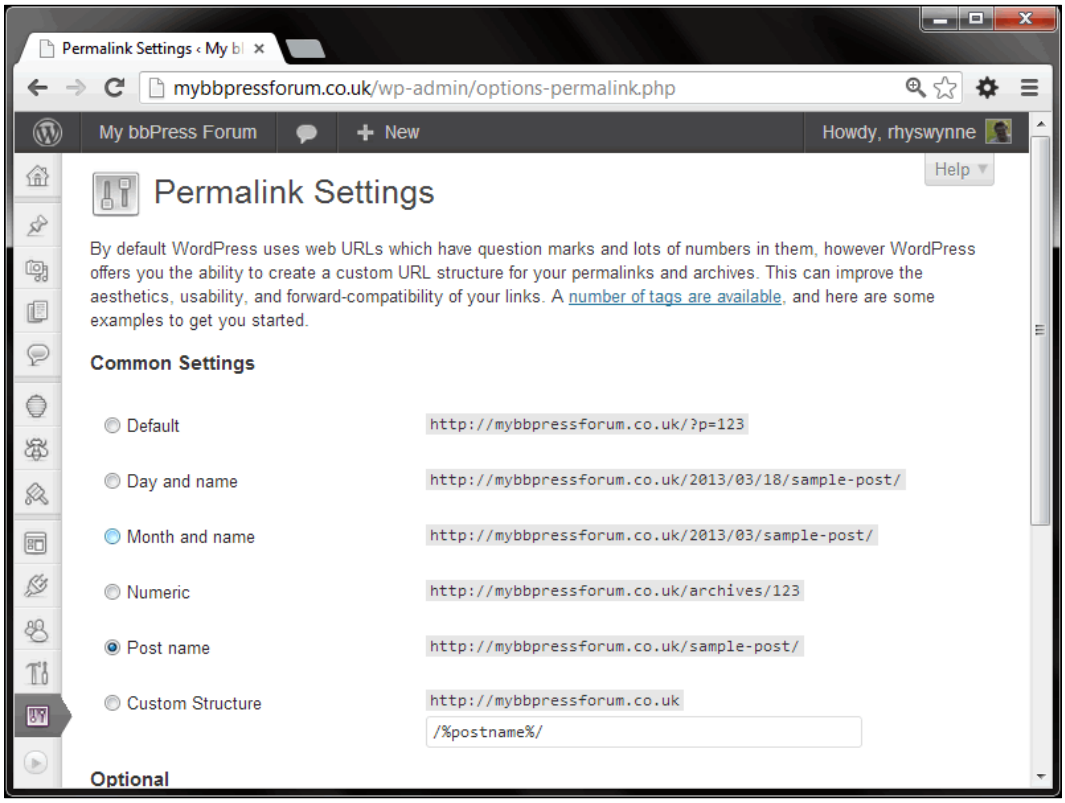
Setting up Pretty Permalinks

By default, WordPress uses a permalink structure that has, by its own admission, "question marks and lots of numbers in them". The reason for this is that it's the only structure that works with every type of service out there.

It isn't perfect though; for one, it's difficult to remember post names and pages. For example, which of the following two links is easier to remember: `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/?p=1204892` or `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/my-brand-new-post/`? The latter is much easier to remember and share with users, isn't it? Also, having words in URLs helps search engines, as they use the page URL as a guide to what is on the page. Having an easy-to-remember URL is what is known in WordPress as **Pretty Permalinks**, and is a good practice for any site to be **search engine friendly** (**SEF**).

To set these up is simple. If you remember, in *Chapter 1, Getting Started with bbPress*, we asked our host if they had a service called "mod_rewrite". This service allows WordPress to have these Pretty Permalinks, and it's incredibly easy to set up, so much so that many blogs or WordPress installations already have it set up.

If you haven't already done so, head to the **Permalinks** section in your WordPress Administration (it's a submenu under **Settings**) and you should be greeted with this page, as shown in the following screenshot, with the top option checked:

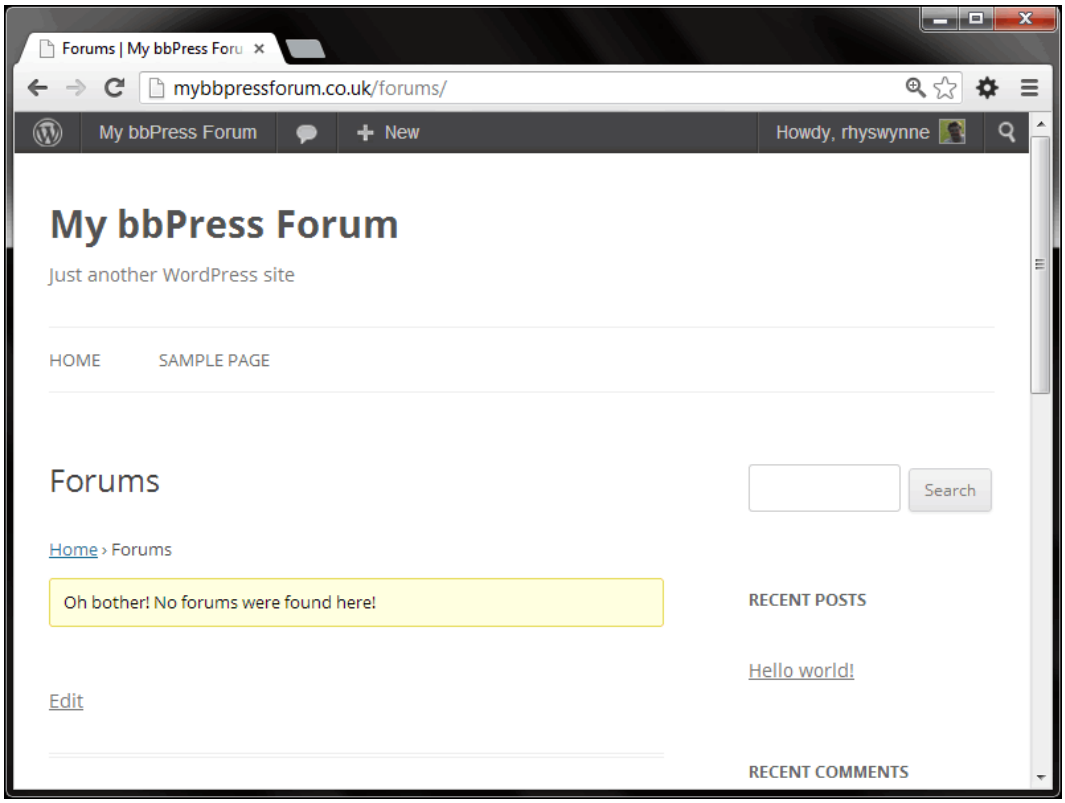


Select any other radio button apart from **Default.** I recommend the **Post Name** or **Month and name** radio button as shown in the preceding screenshot, as then, the URL will contain the name of the post, helping search engines find it easier, and people to remember it easier. Then, click on **Save Changes**.

This will change all the URLs on your site; so on established sites, I would recommend that you check all your most important pages to see if they still appear. The old URLs will still work, but will redirect to the new, prettier URLs.

> A lot of the rest of this book will talk about the forums and posts in Pretty Permalink format, so while not essential, it will make understanding this book easier.

To test that your forum works now, visit `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/forums/`, and you should see the following screen:



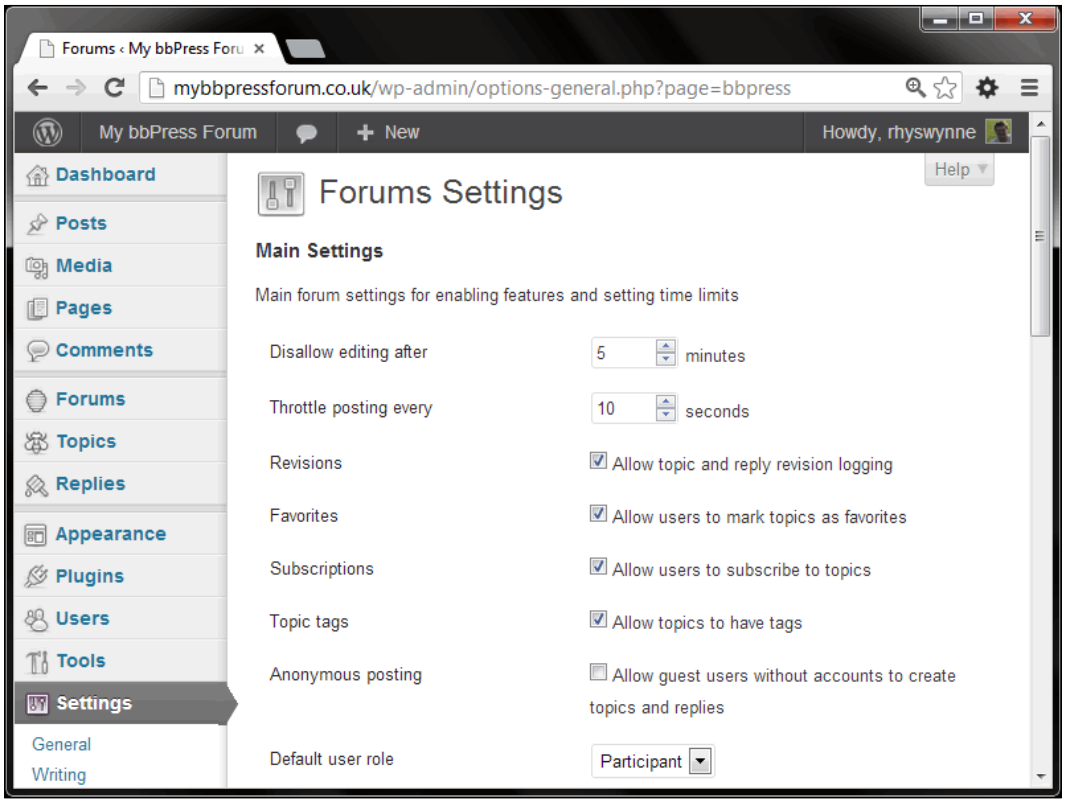
There isn't much to see yet, but don't worry, we'll soon be filling this page out with forums, posts, and topics.

The bbPress settings page

Before you launch any forum, it's important to visit the bbPress settings page and check over the options to make sure they are according to your requirements.

By default, bbPress populates the options with the most common settings. However, it may not be suitable for all, so it's a worthwhile check to make.

To view this page, within the WordPress Administration Dashboard, head to the **Forums** options page, which is a subpage of **Settings**. It is *not* the **Forums** page you see in the sidebar. To make sure you are viewing the correct screen, you should check with the following screenshot:



This section is split into four subsections, **Main Settings**, which sets global settings to the forum**, Per Page**, **which sets up the forum's display settings on the page, and Archive** and **Single Slugs**, which sets up the forum's Pretty Permalinks, as discussed earlier in this chapter.

Main Settings

This sets up the global settings of the forums. Most forums will want to keep the settings the same or similar to the default settings. However, we will go through each setting to explain what each one does and what should be the likely value.

Disallow editing after (x) minutes

This setting allows users to edit for a short period of time after posting. This is primarily done to allow users to correct spelling mistakes or confusions. As such, most corrections would probably be done within five minutes, which is the default value.

I would recommend keeping it at five minutes. For forums that constantly receive posts from users (for example, suppose a user is editing a post, then another user quotes that post, then they both will quote the original post, and so on), I would recommend reducing it further.

Throttle posting every (x) seconds

This setting sets the time between each user's posts. This is done to prevent users from creating duplicate topics as a result of clicking on the **Submit** button multiple times. By default, users can post once every 10 seconds.

I would recommend increasing it to 30 seconds, as on many forums, users won't be able to write a post or reply within 30 seconds, and it also stops manual spammers (people posting the same post over and over again).

Allow topic and reply revision logging

This keeps a record of each topic and reply that is edited. Only Keymasters will be able to view this and make changes. It's worthwhile keeping this on, unless your forum gets exceptionally large, as it could make your site slow. However, for most forums, it's a good idea to keep this switched on, which is its default value.

Favorites and Subscriptions

The next two options allow the users to set topics as **Favorites** or **Subscriptions**. Favorites is a list of favorite topics that the users have, and it is displayed in the user's profile. Subscriptions are also publicly accessible in the user's profile; however, users will be notified whenever a new post is made in a subscribed topic. Both are on by default, and are recommended to be kept on.

Allow topics to have tags

You can "tag" topics. Tags are words associated with each topic, and can be used to quickly find relevant posts. Say for example, you have a forum with two sections, "Travel" and "Sport". The Travel section could have posts tagged with the word "Spain" (for example, a post that tells about travelling to Spain). The Sport section could have posts tagged with the word "Sport" (for example, a post that tells about Spanish football). It can be a good way to help users on busy forums navigate to relevant topics easily, but it can also be open to abuse. It's a good idea to set this on to begin with, and then see what happens on your forum.

Anonymous posting

If checked, this setting will allow the users that are not logged in to post on your site. I would leave this setting switched off, as the amount of spam that will come to your forum will be almost unmanageable if switched on.

The default user role

This is the default role of users when they first visit the site. We will talk in more detail about user roles in the next chapter, but for now, if you want users to join the site and post straight away, set it to **Participant**. If you want to approve new members, set it to **Spectator**.

The auto role

By default, any new member who registers for the site will have no role assigned, and therefore assumes the "default" user role as defined previously. Rather than leaving the role for each user empty, this option actually assigns the user the default role.

It's a good idea to switch this option off. This enables you to change the default role at any time. But then, you will have to go through every user and change this. Also, it has been known to cause problems with certain installations.

The fancy editor

This changes the editor box from a blank textbox to the one with a toolbar, which allows rich text (such as bold, italicized, and underlining text) to be easily added. It is on by default and should be left on.

Auto-embed links

This option will allow users to embed content (such as tweets, YouTube videos, and Flickr images) into the posts by simply adding the URL to that content on a new line. You can read a full description of how this works as well as a full and updated list of services supported, at `http://codex.wordpress.org/Embeds`, but as a rule of thumb, if you want the users to embed Youtube videos into the forum, leave this option switched on; alternatively, you can switch this off.

Per page settings

This is quite simple. This setting allows you to specify how many topics you can have on each page of the forum, and how many replies you should have on each page of the topic. A number between 10 and 25 is usually the standard.

Archive and single Slugs

Remember we talked about Pretty Permalinks earlier? Well, **Slugs** are a part of the URL that occurs between slashes after the domain name. This will allow you to have a hierarchical structure in your forum. So, for example, your "Travel" forum we discussed earlier may have a URL structure of `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/forums/forum/travel/`. This makes it easy for users to remember and find, and can also help to find the post through search engines.

By default, you should probably leave these settings as they are. The only reason you should change this is if you have any post or page on your site with the URL `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/forums/` or `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/topics/`, as this can cause conflict issues between WordPress and bbPress.

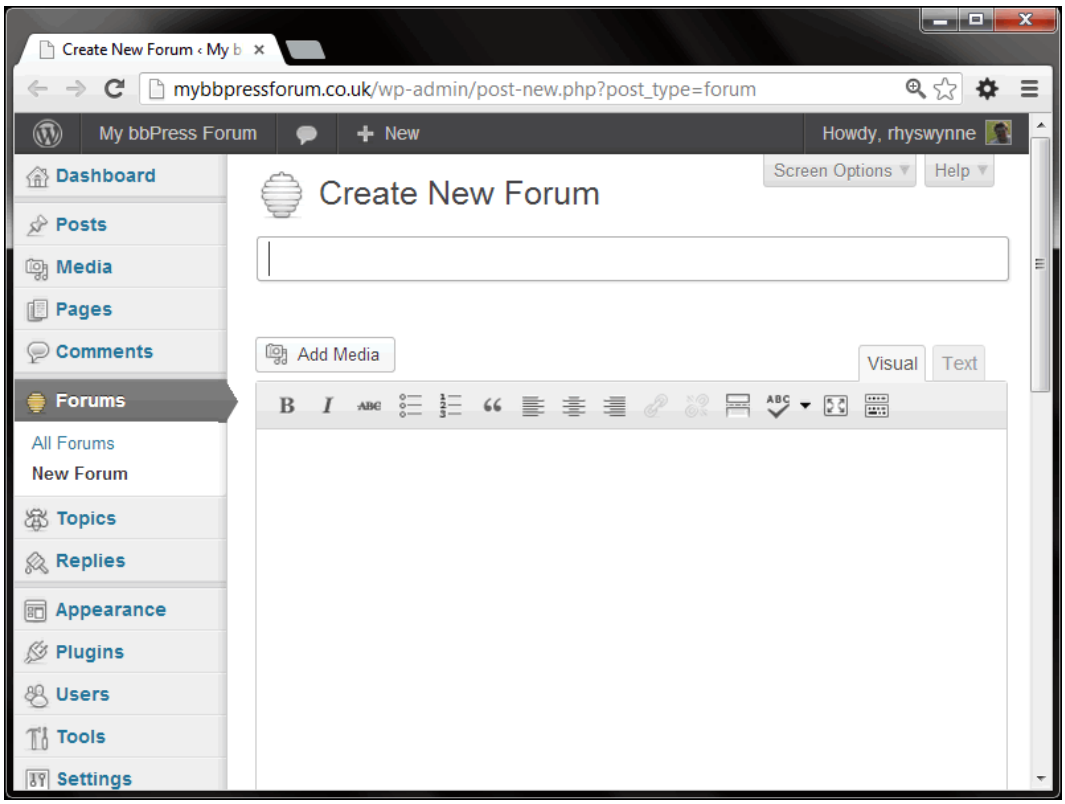
When satisfied, click on **Save Changes** and the changes should be saved.

Forums

Now that bbPress is set up exactly how you want it, we're now going to create a few forums. Most forums, even those that are extremely specialized, have a variety of sections to help users navigate through the site. bbPress makes it easy to create and manage sections, but for now, let us first create a brand new forum.

Creating a new forum

In the WordPress Administration, click on **New Forum**, which is a subpage of the **Forums** menu item on the sidebar. You will be taken to a screen that is quite similar to a WordPress post creation page, but slightly different with a few extra areas:



If you are not familiar with the WordPress post creation page, the following is a list of the page's features:

The Enter Title Here box

The long box on the top of the page is your forum title. This, on the forum page, will be what is clicked on, and will also provide the basis for the forum's URL Slug with some changes, as URL Slugs generally have to be letters, numbers, and dashes. So for example, if your forum title is **My Product's Support Section**, your Slug will probably be **my-products-support-section**.

When you insert the forum title, the URL Slug will be generated below. However, if you wish to change it, click on the yellow highlighted section to change the Slug, and then click on **OK**.

The Post box

Beneath the title box is the post box. This should contain your forum description. This will be shown beneath your forum's name on the forum index page. You can add rich text to this, such as bold or italicized text, but my advice is to keep this short. One or two lines of text would suffice, otherwise it could make your forum look peculiar.

Forum attributes

Towards the right-hand side of the screen, you should see a **Forum Attributes** section. bbPress allows to set a number of different attributes for your created forum. The attributes are explained in detail as follows:

- **Forum type**: Your forum can be one of two types: "Forum" or "Category". Category is a section of the site where you cannot post, but forums are grouped in. So for example, if you have forums for "Football", "Cricket", and "Athletics", you may group them into a "Sport" category.
- Unless you have a large forum with a number of different areas, you shouldn't need many categories. Normally you would begin with a few forums, but then as your forums grow, you would introduce categories.

> If you create a category, any forum you create must be a subforum of the category. We will talk about creating subforums later in this chapter.

- **Status**: Your forum's status indicates if other users can post in the forum. If the status is "**Open",** any user can post in the forum. If the forum is "**Closed",** nobody can contribute other than Keymasters. Unless one of your forums is a "Forum Rules" forum, you would probably keep all forums as Open.

- **Visibility**: bbPress allows three types of forum visibility. These, as the names suggest, decide who gets to see the forums. The three options are as follows:
    - **Public**: This type allows anybody visiting the site to see the forum and its contents.
    - **Private**: This type allows users who are logged in to view and contribute to the forum, but the forum is hidden from users that are not logged in or users that are blocked. Private forums are prefixed with the word "Private".
    - **Hidden**: This type allows only Moderators and Keymasters to view the forum.

  Most forums will probably have majority of their forums set to Public, but have selections that are Private or Hidden. Usually, having a Hidden forum to discuss forum matters with Administrators or Moderators is a good thing. You can have a private forum as well that could help encourage people to register on the site.

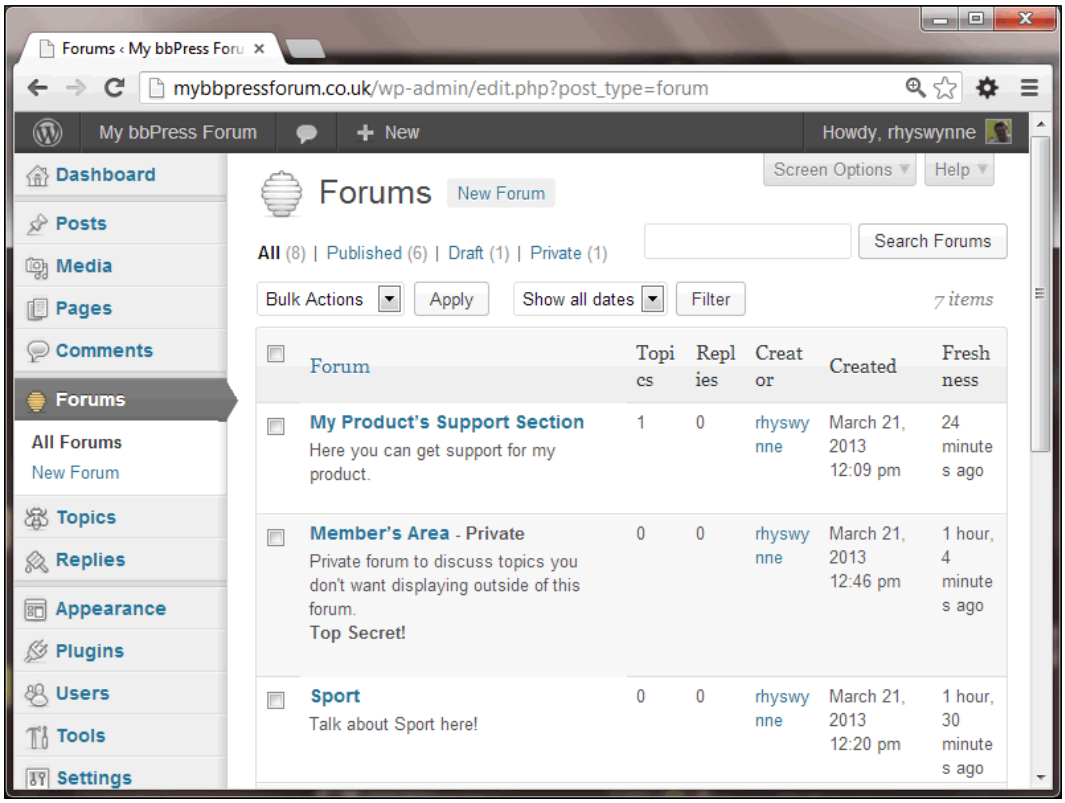
- **Parent**: You can have subforums of forums. By giving a parent to the forum, you make it a subforum. An example of this would be if you had a "Travel" forum, you can have subforums dedicated to "Europe", "Australia", and "Asia". Again, you will probably start with just a few forums, but over time, you will probably grow your forum to include subforums.
- **Order**: The Order field helps define the order in which your forums are listed. By default, or if unspecified, the order is always alphabetical. However, if you give a number, then the order of the forum will be determined by the Order number, from smallest to largest. It is good to put important forums at the top, and less important forums towards the bottom of the page.

It's a good idea to number your orders in multiples of 10, rather than 1, 2, 3, and so on. That way, if you want to add a forum to your site that will be between two other forums, you can add it in with a number between the two multiples of 10, thus saving time.

Now that you have set up a forum, click on **publish**, and congratulations, you should have a forum!

Editing and deleting forums

Forums are a community, and like all good communities, they evolve over time depending on their user's needs. As such, over time, you may need to restructure or delete forums. Luckily, this is easily done. First, click on **Forums** in the sidebar of the WordPress Administration. You should see a list of all the current forums you have on your site:



If you hover over a forum, two options will appear: **Edit**, which will allow you to edit the forum. A screen similar to the New Forum page will appear, which will allow you to make changes to your forum.

The second option is **Trash**, which will move your forum into Trash. After a while, it will be deleted from your site.

> When you click on **Trash**, you will trash *everything* associated with your forum (any topics, replies, or tags will be deleted). *Be careful!*

Forum posts – topics and replies

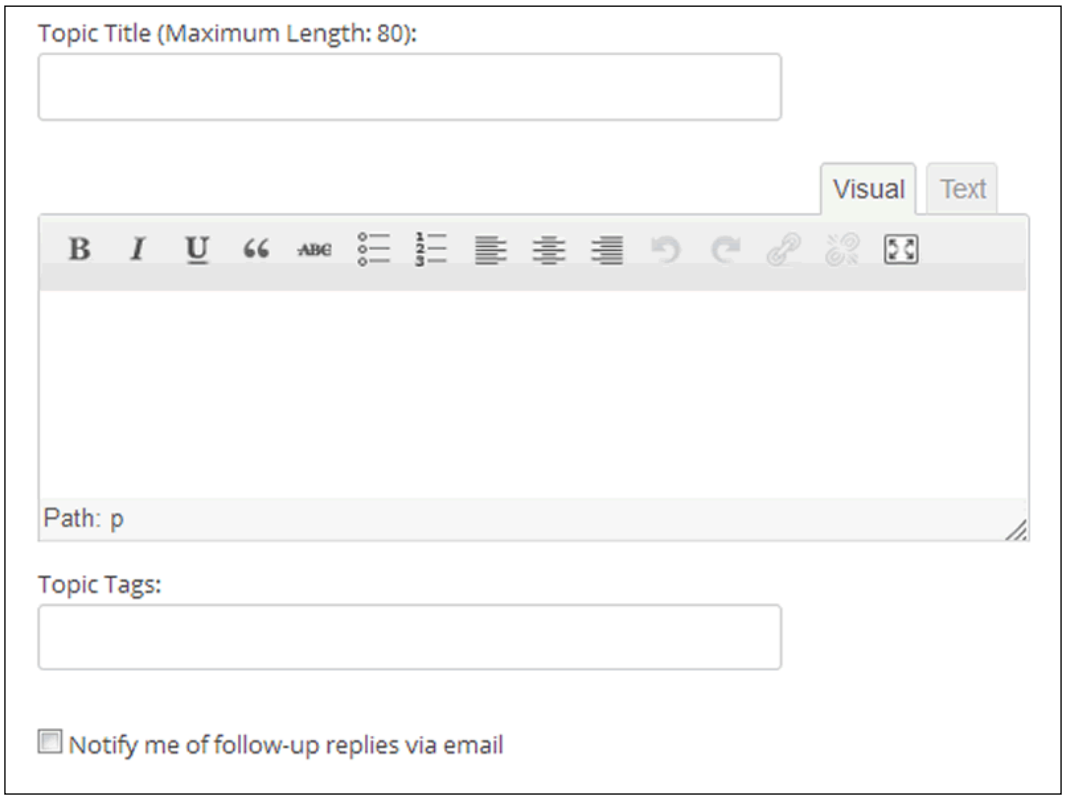
Having a number of forums on your site is all well and good, but for a forum to be successful, you need to have some posts and discussions in there.

To begin with, you will probably have to start with a few discussions and reply a fair bit as well. It will take time, but eventually some of your members will contribute, meaning you can take a step back as the forum continues to grow.

There are a couple of ways for adding forum posts to the site. However, I'm going to show you the easiest and more common way of adding posts, which is the same way through which your readers will add posts.

Adding new posts

Go to `http://www.yourwordpressdomain.com/forums/` and navigate to the forum that you want to add a post to. Beneath any posts already made, you should see a box with the title **Create New Topic in…** and then your forum's name.



The **Topic Title** textbox and post box are fairly self explanatory, and you should be familiar with what this will contain. However, **Topic Tags** is a new section. We discussed tags previously as being a list of keyword phrases used to help users find similar topics within different forums. Include a list of comma-separated words to help users find related posts.

The **Notify me of follow-up replies via email** checkbox will subscribe you to the topic, so that when somebody replies, you will receive an e-mail alerting you to the new replies.

Finally, if you are a Moderator or a Keymaster, you will have an extra box: **Topic type**. Topics can be one of three types:

- **Normal**: This is your standard topic useful for pretty much all topics.
- **Sticky**: The Sticky topic will be "stuck" to the top of the page. By default, whenever new topics get added, or replies are added to topics, they go above older discussions. Sticky topics are kept permanently at the top of the forum. This is useful for definitions, links to major forum discussions or frequently asked questions, as well as major forum events such as offline meet ups.
- **Super Sticky**: These topics will be displayed on the top of *all* the forums, above all the Sticky topics and the Normal topics. This is useful for posts that are universal throughout the site, such as forum rules.

When you are ready, click on **Publish** and then your post will be published. Congratulations! You have just published your first post.

Replying to topics

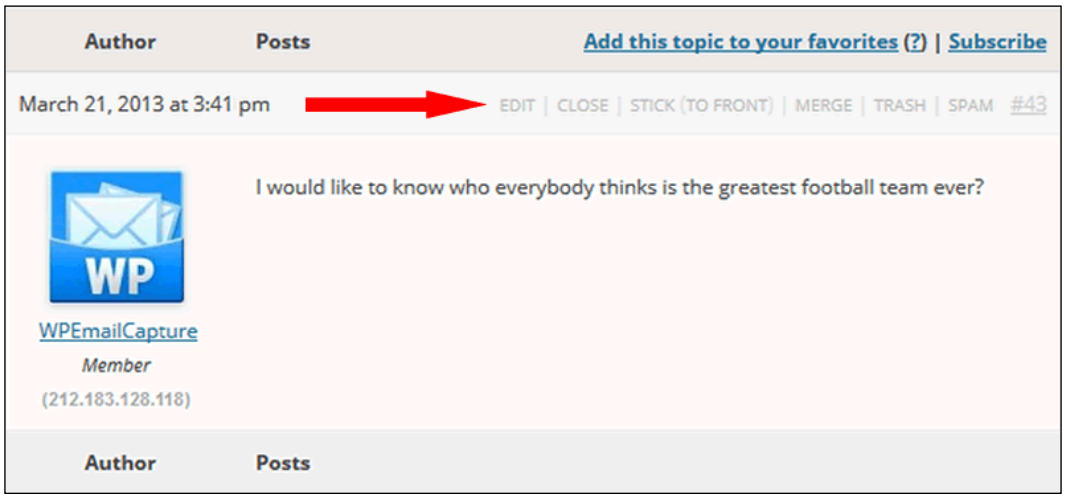
When you have created a topic and clicked on **Publish**, your topic goes live and is open to replies from users. You can also reply to your own topic; this is handy if you have run out of time to edit the original topic and need to add something to your original post.

To reply to a topic, navigate to any topic whose discussion is still open. Beneath any post, you will see a reply box. The only difference will be that you cannot provide it with a title as the title of the topic is set at the beginning.

You can add your reply in the post box and also add any extra tags to it. You also have the option in the checkbox to subscribe to the post again. When you are happy, click on **Submit** and you will be taken back to the post page, with your reply added to the topic.

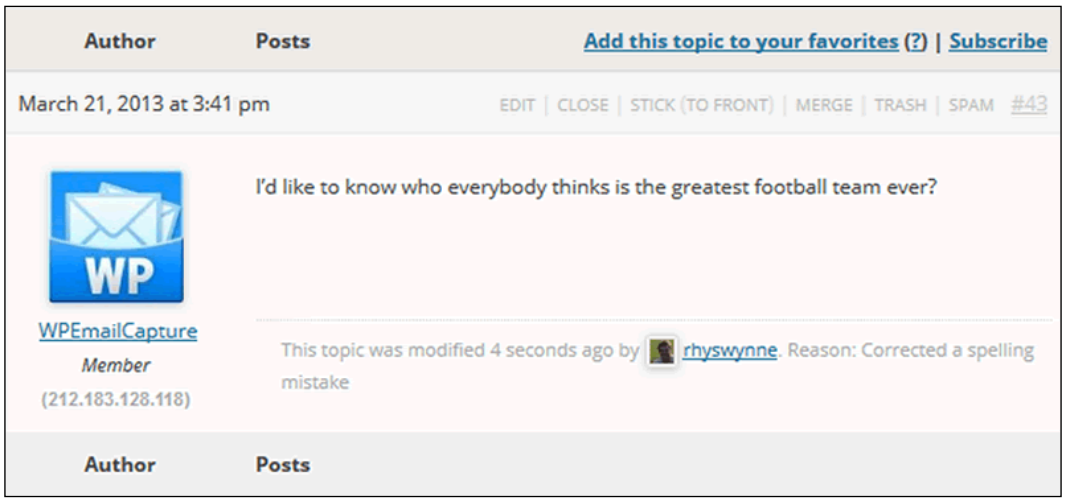
Topic and Reply Management

If you are either a Keymaster or a Moderator, you will have access to the advanced features for topics. These are presented to you when you are browsing the forum so that they can be easily accessed. You will be able to see these options by default above each post, and they are crucial to know about, if you are managing your forum. They are shown in the following screenshot:



Edit

Edit is available to all the users depending on how far you limit them to edit their posts. However, Moderators and Keymasters can edit posts at any point of time. Clicking on **Edit** will take you to a page where you can make changes to the post. However, at the bottom, there is a **Keep a Log Of this Edit** checkbox and an **Optional Reason for Editing** textbox. Tick the checkbox and give a reason if needed. If you have kept a log, it will be displayed under the edited post as shown in the following screenshot:



If you want your forum to be a success, then you would have to be open with your community. Editing posts and not giving reasons, or even worse, editing them without any visual notification to let people know that their posts have been edited, can lead to members leaving forums. So try to justify your actions.

Closed/open topics

This option will close or open the topic to new replies. Generally, if a discussion ends up going wildly off the topic with only few people adding valuable posts, or if it descends into an argument, it's a good idea to close the discussion for new replies.

Stick/unstick (to front)

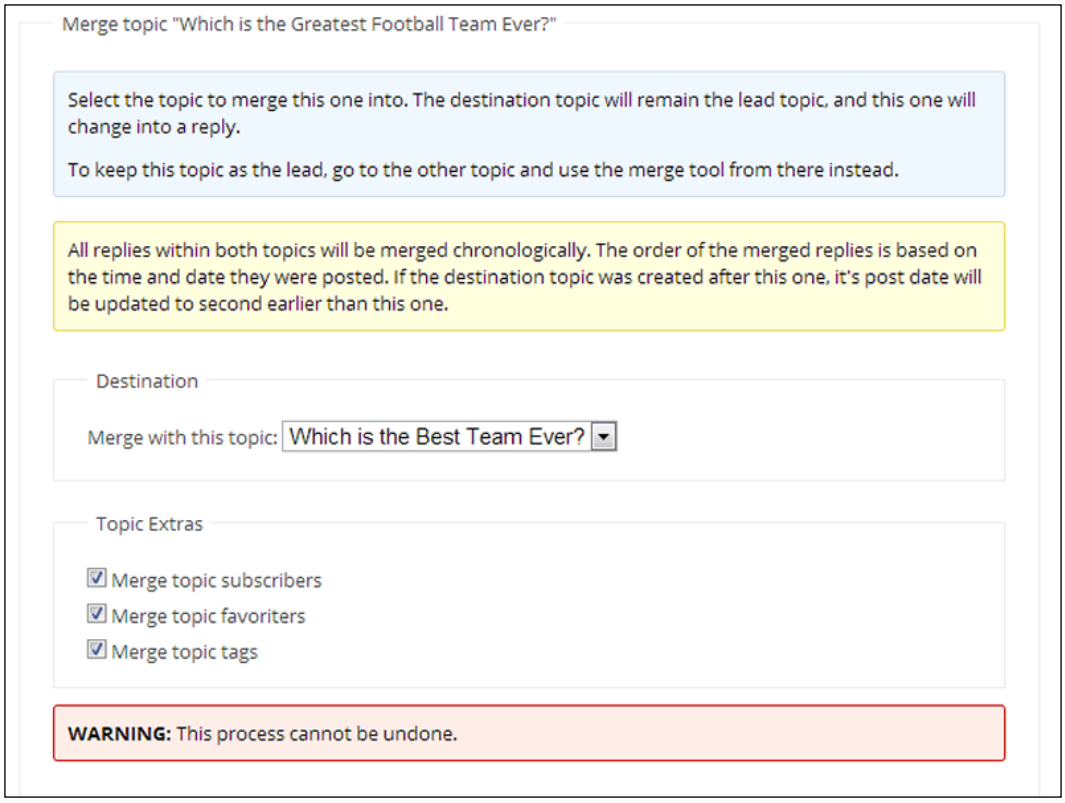
This option will stick the topic to the top of the page. Generally, users will probably ask you to do this if they have an important discussion or event going on. Alternatively, you may do this if the topic proves useful to the new users, and you want them to see this.

You can also make it a Super Sticky topic by clicking on **To Front**.

Merge topics

Occasionally, users will accidentally create two topics asking exactly the same thing at the same time. It may therefore be necessary to merge the two topics together. This can be done using "Merge".

Clicking on **Merge** will take you to a screen that looks something like this:



Any page where you click on **Merge** will merge that topic with the destination topic. You may want to click on **Merge** for a later post or for a topic that has the least activity. In the drop-down list under **Destination**, select the post on your forum, and then click on **Submit**. This will merge the two topics together, maintaining the order in which replies were posted. *Remember***,** this process cannot be undone.

You can only merge topics within a forum, and cannot cross forums.

Trash

Trashing a post removes it from the forum. It's a good idea to trash posts that are just taking up space, for example, posts from the same user that are accidentally posted twice.

Spam

If you click on **Spam**, it removes the post from the forum, marks it for deletion, and also marks it as spam. Therefore, any future posts by that user may also be marked as spam. This is done if users are deliberately posting topics that are hateful, overly advertising, or are full of links to their other sites.

Summary

You should now have the beginning of a successful forum. It's a good idea before starting a forum to post a few topics to give your new users something to reply to.

You should also begin now to advertise your forum around. By doing so, you will begin to get people to visit your forum. People need to be managed though. In the next chapter, we will talk about user management.

3
User Management in bbPress

By now you should be getting more traffic on your site, and also begin to see people signing up to your site and participating in your forum. While this is a great thing and the majority of people visiting your site will be welcomed, it can cause a few issues every now and again, with troublesome users.

Thankfully, bbPress does come with a multitude of features on how to deal with the most important asset to your forum—its members. Members can make or break your forum, so it is vital you manage them effectively. As such, this chapter will give you all the tools to help you manage your members and present them in the best light, and will cover the following topics:

- Gravatars – what are they and how to create one
- Your user profile – what it contains and how to make changes to it
- User roles – what each role is and what capabilities they have
- How to set users to each of the roles in question

By the end of the chapter, you should have all the tools you need to manage your forum effectively. Now let's begin by giving you the tools that will help you to set up your profile perfectly.

Setting up your administration profile

As it is your forum, you will be seen as the leader of it, and as such it's a good idea to set up your profile as thoroughly as possible, and include as many ways as possible for users to get in contact with you with grievances or suggestions. This first section of the chapter will guide you through how to set up your profile.

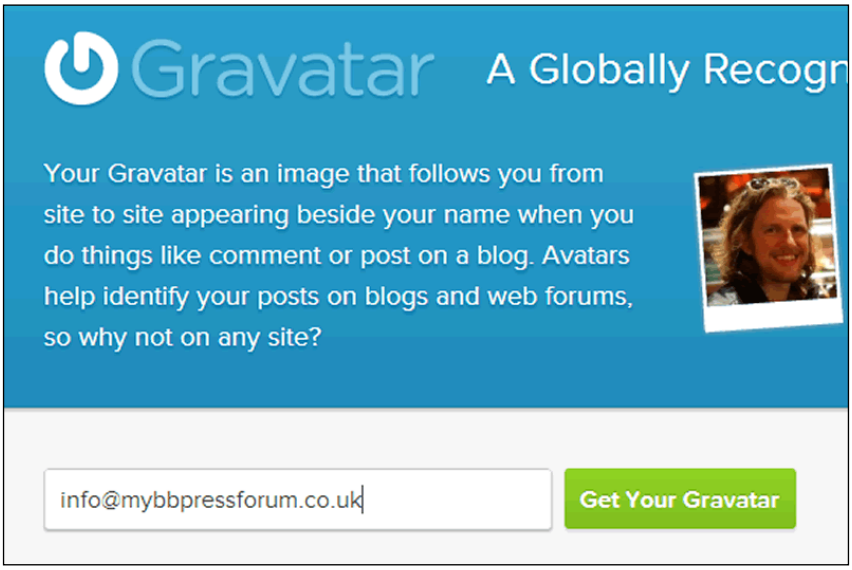
Signing up for Gravatar

The easiest way to stand out in your forum is to use a Gravatar. Gravatar stands for **Globally Recognised Avatar** and it's a service owned by Automattic, which allows you to use the same avatar (a picture associated with yourself) on any Gravatar-enabled site—effectively, any WordPress site. It is automatic, so set this up once and then any site that is Gravatar-enabled will show your Gravatar if you use your e-mail address on it.

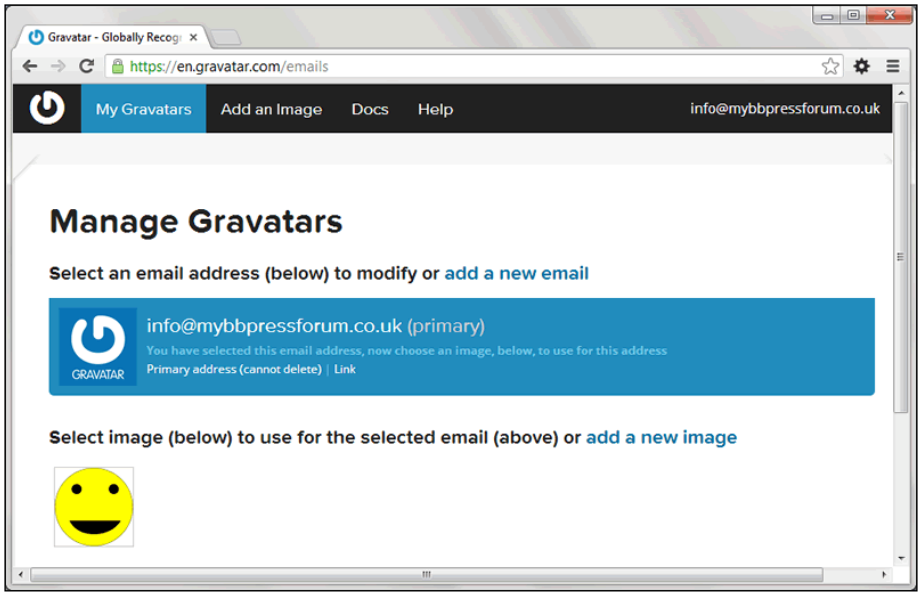
> All Gravatars are tied to an e-mail address, so make sure you use the same e-mail address that is associated with your administration account with bbPress.

To set up your Gravatar, please follow these steps:

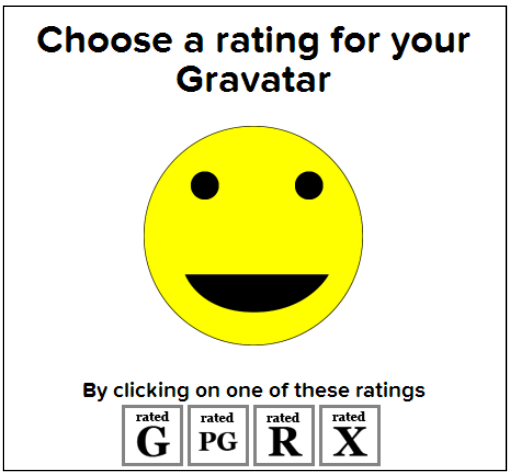
1. Go to `http://www.gravatar.com`, and halfway down the page you should have a box where you can enter your e-mail address. Enter it and click on the **Get Your Gravatar** button.



2. An e-mail will be sent to the address, containing a link for you to click on. Click on it and set up your profile with a username and password. You will then be taken to the **Manage Gravatars** screen.



3. On this screen, there will be a link halfway down the page that will prompt you to upload an image. Click on this link and choose an image source (be it your computer, the Internet, or a previously uploaded image). Find or upload your image and then you'll be given the opportunity to crop or size your image. When finished, click on **Crop and Finish!** and you'll be taken to a screen asking you to choose the rating of your image.



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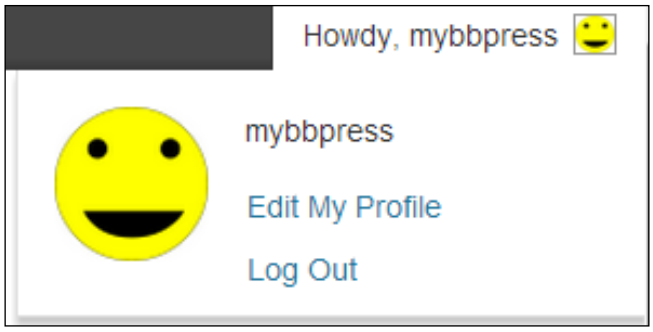
4. Give your image an appropriate rating (most will be a **G** or **PG**, unless your image is likely to offend) and you will be taken back to the home screen, with your avatar displayed next to your default e-mail address (if you have only one e-mail address and only one image).
5. Now return to your bbPress forum and log in. If you visit any of your posts, you should see your Gravatar displayed next to your posts, as shown in the following screenshot:

6. You can change the avatar at any time by going back to `http://www.gravatar.com/`, logging in with your Gravatar username and password, and uploading a replacement to be associated with your e-mail address.

Adding and amending details to your user profile

There are two ways in which changes can be made to your profile. We will look at the second way later, as it is related to administrating the forum, but as we are just dealing with a user profile, we'll edit the profile in a more conventional manner to those familiar with WordPress.

When you have logged in to your bbPress account on your bbPress forum, a black bar will appear along the top of the screen. Towards the right of the bar is your designated bbPress name. If you hover over your name, a drop-down menu will appear similar to the one shown in the following screenshot. Click on the **Edit My Profile** link to edit your profile.



You will be taken to a page within the WordPress administration that allows you to edit your profile. This page is split into three sections by default and depending on the plugins that you add to the site, you could have more options than the ones that we are going to see. The following sections detail the information that you can change or edit on this page (these are the ones available by default).

Personal Options

The **Personal Options** section includes largely the display options for your administration sections, and are therefore personal preferences, and not displayed to anybody else.

Admin Color Scheme

The **Admin Color Scheme** section allows you to change the color scheme for the administration section. With the exception of the toolbar, you won't see this usually, so unless you want to color-coordinate your toolbar with the rest of the site, it shouldn't matter.

Toolbar

The **Toolbar** option allows you to hide the toolbar. This could be handy if the toolbar covers up menus or other items, but usually I leave this switched on.

> This option hides the toolbar from your whole WordPress site, not just the bbPress forum. This is worth bearing in mind.

Name

The **Name** section allows you to set your first and last name, as well as a nickname and the option to display your name publicly. Please note that any information you place here could be displayed on the site, so don't place anything here that you don't want to display publicly.

It's a good idea to either use your first name or a nickname as your display name, rather than your username.

Contact Info

The **Contact Info** section allows you to fill in your contact details for various online services such as AOL Instant Messenger, Yahoo! Instant Messenger, and Google Talk, as well as specify a website and your e-mail address.

If you run a website, it's probably a good idea to include your website as this will be listed on your profile. The most important section, however, is your e-mail address. This is because it is the point of contact if you ever forget your password and need to reset your password. Therefore, you need to make sure your e-mail address is correct and you have access to it. When you change your e-mail address, I recommend you either attempt to reset your password or send yourself an e-mail, to make sure that your e-mail address is correct.

About Yourself

The **About Yourself** section allows you to enter a short biography about yourself. This information is displayed on your profile if anyone views your profile, so include whatever you wish and wouldn't mind being displayed publicly.

New password

The final couple of boxes on your **Dashboard** page will allow you to change your password. This should be the first thing you do when you sign up to a bbPress forum, as the passwords are automatically generated and are difficult to remember. Make your new password easy for you to remember, yet make sure the password is strong with letters, numbers, and punctuation marks. The strength indicator will give you an idea of how strong the password is.

If you change your password, you will be prompted to log in to your site again; when logged in again, you should notice that your profile has been saved with all your new details.

If you are signing up to somebody else's bbPress forum, you may want to check what information is displayed publicly and what information isn't. bbPress does allow details to be displayed easily, so a general rule of thumb is to not include anything that you wouldn't tell somebody publicly.

User roles

Not every forum user is created equal, and I've already mentioned words that may have confused you, such as "Moderator" and "Keymaster". The **User Roles** section will talk about the different roles each user can have and their capabilities.

It should be noted that since bbPress 2.2, the user roles of bbPress have been separate from the user roles of WordPress, so rest assured that setting user roles will allow users to access the forum separately from the rest of the site.

Keymaster

Keymaster is the role every administrator of your site is assigned. Keymasters have full control over everything associated with your forum. They have the ability to change the user levels of all other users. Keymasters also have the ability to create, edit, and delete all forums, and create, edit, and delete all forum topics and replies. They can manage tags as well as have access to all forum moderation tools, such as merging posts, making posts sticky, and closing posts.

They can also block members, and are also the only ones who can undo deleted posts should they still be in the trash.

Keymasters also have access to hidden forums.

As it is a powerful role, you really should have only one Keymaster (yourself).

It is also a good, secure tactic if the Keymaster account isn't used for posting on your forum, as users will then know the username of the Keymaster account; and if you have an unsecure password, the Keymaster account could easily be accessed.

Moderator

Moderator is the next level, and they can do quite a lot. Moderators can create and edit their own forums, and can also create, edit, and delete other users' topics and replies. They can also manage tags as well as have access to all forum-moderation tools such as merging posts, making posts sticky, and closing posts.

They are unable to block members or promote members to moderators. However, they can access hidden forums.

If you regularly post on your forum (which you should), you should probably do it under a Moderator account rather than a Keymaster account. However, when you are just beginning your forum, you should probably only have one Moderator account. However, as the forum grows and workload increases, you should promote some trusted members to Moderators. For most forums, Moderators won't have much work to do, but it is a good idea to have a couple to cover eventualities on moderately busy forums.

Participant

A Participant is the default role for most forums, and will be assigned the level of new users if you do not change the default settings.

Participants can create their own topics and replies, as well as edit their own topics and replies within the time limit set in the forum.

Participants cannot access the hidden forums and cannot see them either. However, they can see and post in private forums, which are assigned the suffix **Private:**.

As stated earlier, if you want new members to post straight away, set the default user role for new members to Participant.

Spectator

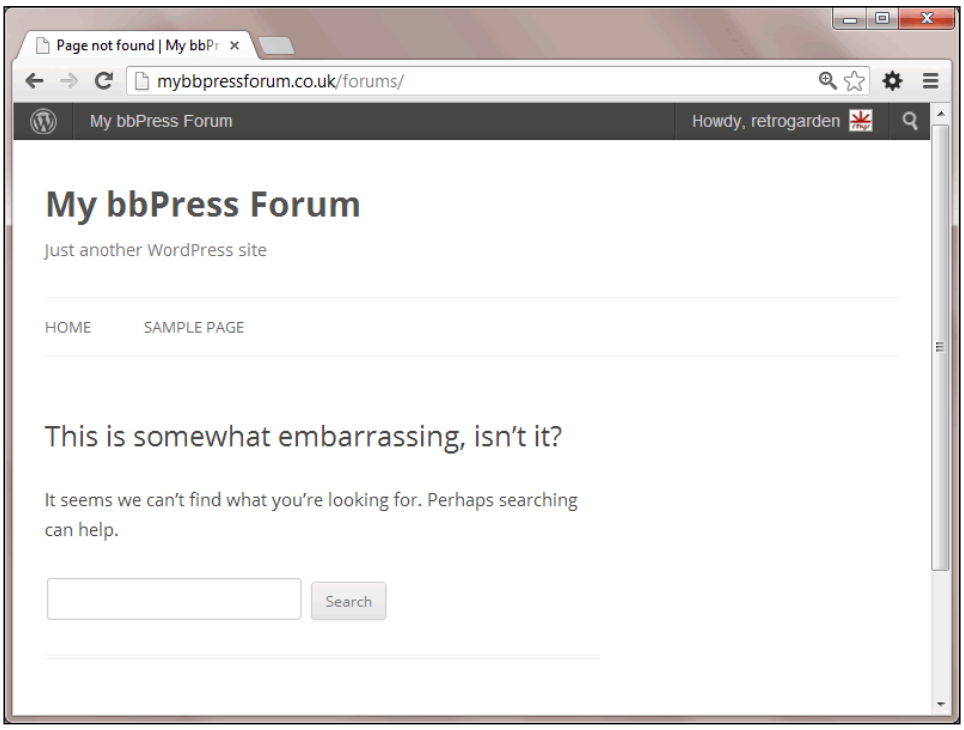
Spectators are members who can read all forums (including private forums when logged in). However, they are unable to post. They can edit their profile details, and so will have a page on the site available to them.

Unless you explicitly set new members to be spectators (who only have the ability to post after you approve each member and turn them into a Participant), you probably will not use the Spectator level too much.

One use of the Spectator level though is for temporarily banning members for 24 hours, say for a warning, for spamming, or for being offensive. However, you will have to manually return them to the Participant level once their ban is complete.

Blocked

Blocked members have no access whatsoever to the forum; instead, the page shown will be a **Page not found** page. An example of what a Blocked member sees is shown in the following screenshot:



They still have access to their user profile and can fill information on it, but they will be unable to access the forum.

The Blocked role should be reserved for members who are disruptive and cause trouble, rather than spambots who sign up to the forum. Spam bots should be deleted and their posts marked as spam, as if you have an Akismet account (which will be discussed in the next chapter), marking posts as spam will contribute to a global database of spam posts, which will help prevent bots spamming your forum and other forums in the future.

By blocking members, you block their e-mail address, preventing them from signing up to your forum again.

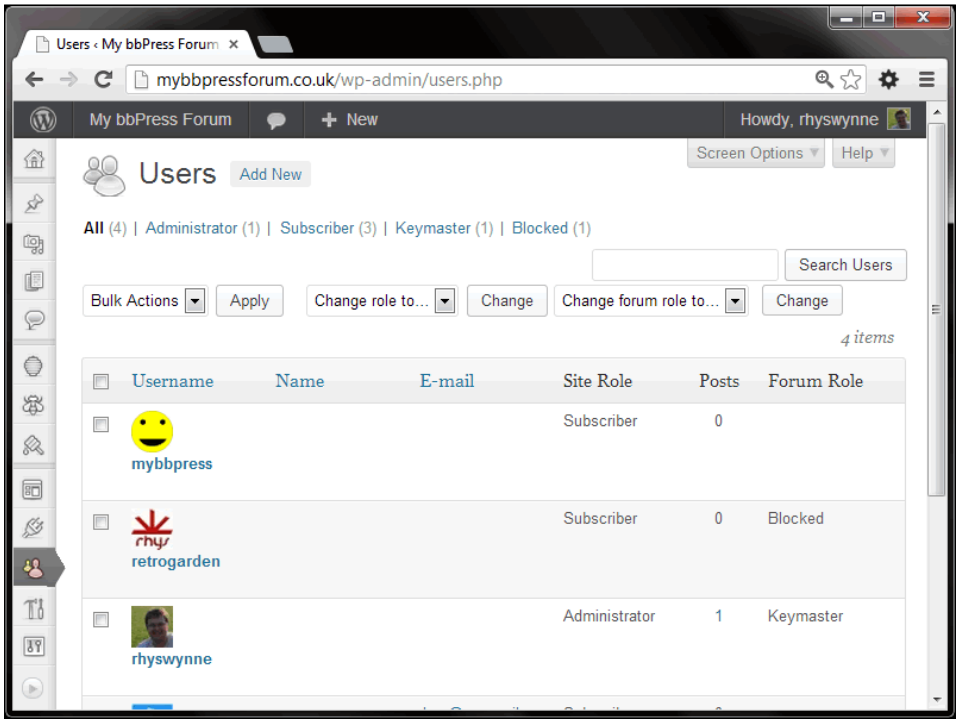
It's worth noting that Blocked members can still read the forum if they are logged out of their account, but are unable to contribute. The only way to prevent this is by making every one of your forums private, but that will affect signups, as potential members won't be able to read the forum before signing up. It isn't worth sabotaging your forum's growth in order to stop a small number of Blocked members from reading your posts.

> You can get an up-to-date guide to each user role and their capabilities at `http://codex.bbpress.org/bbpress-user-roles-and-capabilities/`.

Changing user levels on a large scale

Sometimes there may be a need to change user levels on a mass scale, such as blocking a large number of accounts or changing accounts from Spectator to Participant.

In the WordPress administration, while logged in as a Keymaster, click on the **Users** menu item, and you'll be taken to a page similar to the following screenshot, with a list of all users and e-mail addresses associated with the users:

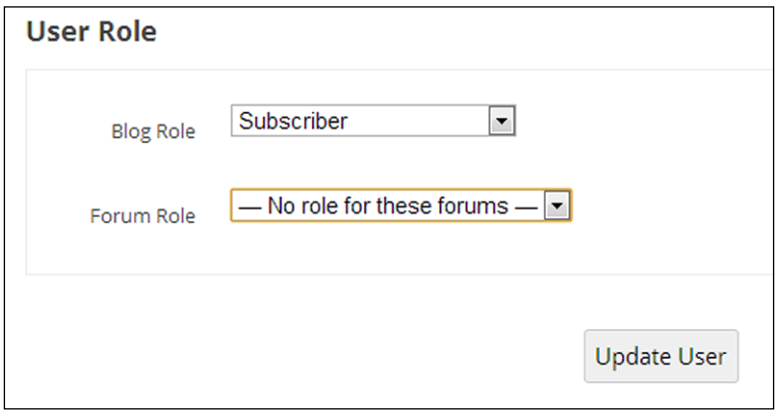


Along the left-hand side of the screen, you'll see a checkbox next to each name. Select the checkbox next to each user whose role you wish to change, and then in the third drop-down box above the **Username** heading (next to the **Change forum role to…** dropdown) select the forum role you wish to change the user accounts to; now click on the **Change** button to the right. This will change all selected users' roles to the forum role selected.

Changing user levels individually

The mass-changing method described previously is fine for changing multiple users, but what if you are browsing the forum and want to quickly block or upgrade a user? Luckily, there's an easy way to do this from within the forum itself.

On browsing the forum, you will notice that any mention of a user's name is hyperlinked. This links to their profile page (similar to the one you set up for yourself at the beginning of this chapter). There will be links in the sidebar of the profile page, and if you are logged in as a Keymaster you will see an **Edit** link. Click it and you will be taken to a page where you can edit any information given for the user. Near the bottom, you will see a **User Role** section as shown in the following screenshot:



The second drop-down box will allow you to select a forum role for the user. Select the chosen forum role and then click on **Update User**. This will update that user to the selected forum role.

While you can edit a fair amount of a user's account on this page, it is recommended that unless asked by the user, you don't change anything as long as it doesn't break your forum's rules. If so, tell the user. Changing user information can lead to mistrust and people leaving your forum. Sometimes, even broken rules are better fixed with a notice asking the user to change it before you do.

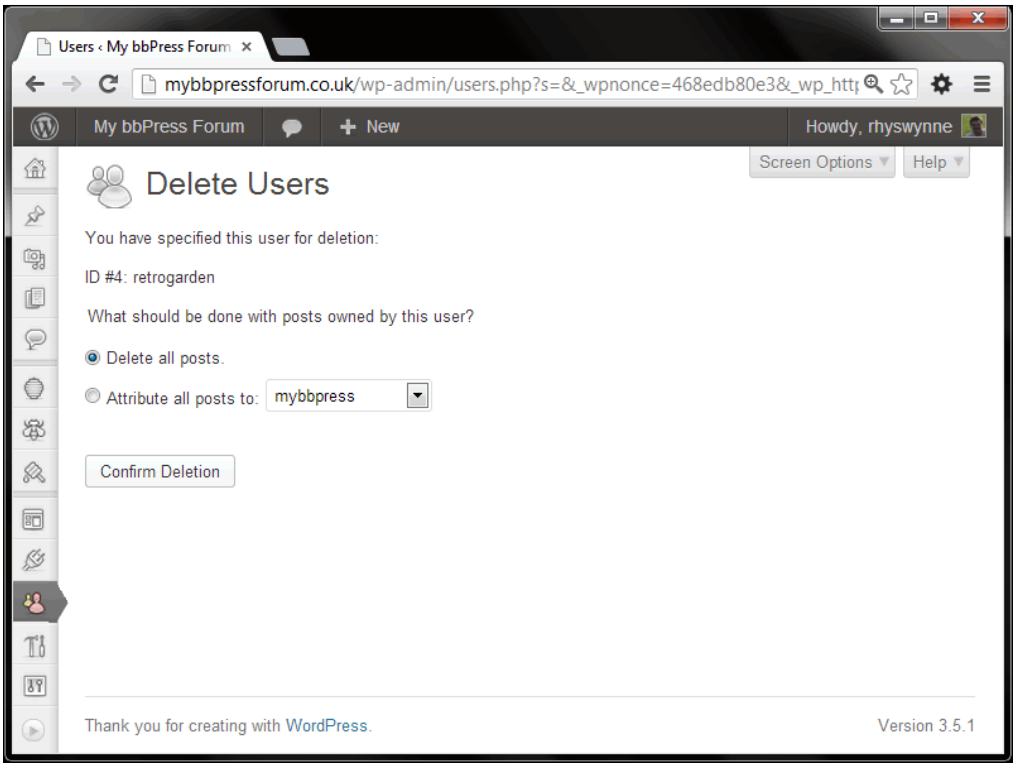
Deleting spam accounts

Spam accounts are not wanted on any forum, and are better dealt with when they are deleted for good.

We will get into dealing with spam in the next chapter, with two methods on how to prevent it; however, even with these two methods enabled, some spam may occur and it accumulates over time. In reality, the best way to deal with it is to delete it.

In your WordPress administration, visit the **Users** page, and just like the method described previously for mass editing, click on the checkbox next to every user you wish to delete.

In the **Bulk Actions** dropbox, which is located above the checkboxes, select **Delete** and click on **Apply**. You will then be offered a choice on what to do with the posts this user has made, as shown in the following screenshot:



As it is a spam account, select **Delete all posts** and then click on **Confirm Deletion**. The user will then be deleted. Spam users don't get a notification when they are classified as spam accounts.

Summary

Right now, you should have a bustling forum, ably overseen by yourself and maybe even a couple of Moderators.

Remember that all I have described so far has been how to use bbPress to manage your forum, and not how to manage your forum. Each forum will have its own rules and guidelines, and you will eventually learn how to manage your bbPress forum with more and more members joining in.

A general rule of thumb, though, is set out your rules at the start of your forum, welcome change, act quickly on violations, and most importantly, treat your users with respect. As without users, you will have a very quiet forum.

That's it! We have discussed all that bbPress can do as a plugin. However, bbPress is a WordPress plugin, and in itself can be extensible and can take advantage of plugins and themes, both specifically designed for bbPress or even those that work with WordPress.

In the next chapter we will look at a range of plugins—some of which have specifically designed with bbPress in mind—designed to extend your forum, making it similar to other more expensive forum management systems. Now the fun starts!

4
Extending bbPress Using Plugins

One of the reasons why bbPress is popular is because when installed on your website, it is light. bbPress is designed so that when installed, it doesn't corrupt your current site or slow it down. However that does come at a small price as straight out of the box, bbPress doesn't quite have the multitude of features that other solutions offer. This is easily fixed by plugins.

Plugins are additional modules designed to expand the functionality of WordPress and bbPress. In fact, bbPress itself is a plugin of WordPress. As WordPress is open source, the majority of the WordPress and bbPress plugins are made by communities. Some are unsupported, whereas others have full support. As such, this chapter will help you navigate the vast WordPress plugin library as well as the 100 plus or so bbPress plugins; by the end of the chapter, you will learn the following topics:

- How to use plugins to add the following features to your bbPress forum
- How to prevent your forum from being spammed
- Adding signatures to your posts
- Adding attachments to your posts
- Set up e-mail notifications for bbPress
- Highlighting unread posts
- How to create a **User(s) online** section of the site allowing you to see who is online at any time on your forum
- Questions to ask yourself before adding a bbPress plugin to your site
- Common bbPress functions on how to make your own plugin

By the end of this chapter, you should have a much more feature-rich forum, know all about the plugin library on WordPress, and may even be confident enough to build your own plugins.

As we have a lot to cover in this chapter, I'm going to skip explaining how to install and activate plugins. Both processes were covered in *Chapter 1*, *Getting Started with bbPress*, where we discussed installing and activating bbPress. A similar process is involved here. I will tell you what I search for in each plugin.

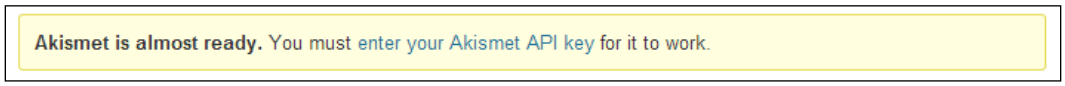
Spam protection

A crucial component, on which many successful forums are judged, is the ability to deal with spam posts. Spam is unfortunately a fact of life on the Internet these days, but luckily, tools are getting better at combating this. WordPress has two bbPress compatible tools that can be used to combat spam.

Blocking spam posts – Akismet

Akismet is written by Automattic to help prevent spam posts. It collects anonymous data from your site via a key, collates it with all other Akismet activated services, and analyzes comments and posts to find a common connection on spam and use that to automatically mark future posts as spam.

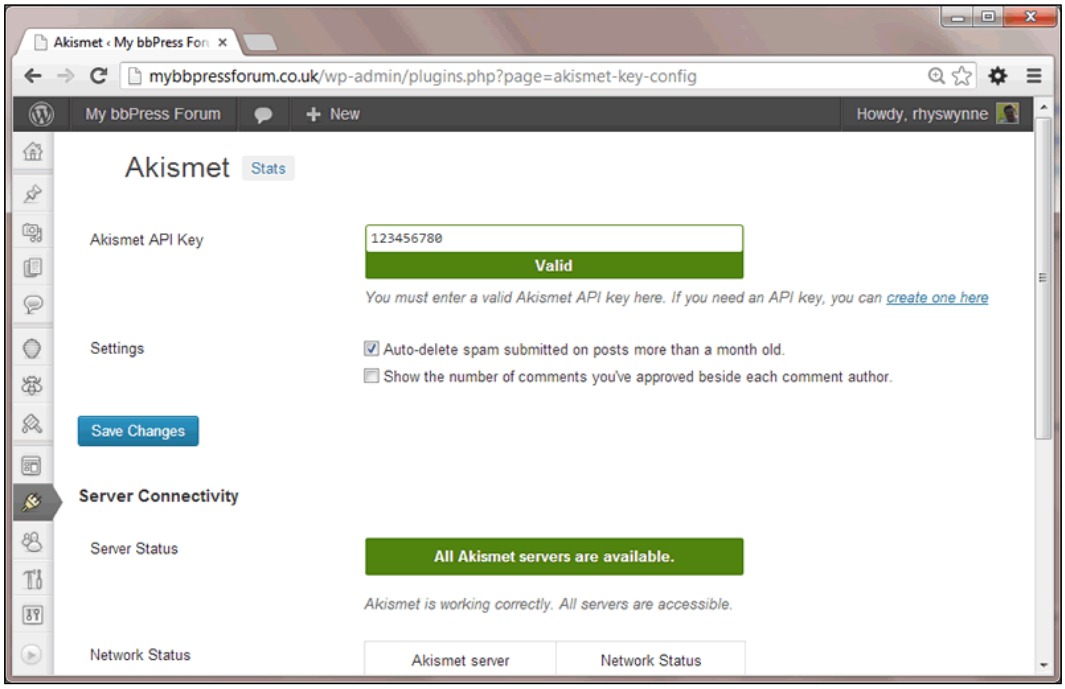
Akismet comes with WordPress, so activate it (if not, you can find an installation of it if you search for the plugin repository for Akismet). You will be prompted to enter your Akismet key, as shown in the following screenshot:



The following steps are to be taken to reduce spam:

1. Go to `http://www.akismet.com` and click on **Get a WordPress Key**. Pick a plan, either **Pro** (if you run a commercial site) or **Personal** (if your site is nonprofit), and you will be encouraged to sign up via `WordPress.com`. Remember when you created an account for your Gravatar? The same details work here.
2. Click on **I already have a WordPress.com account!** and log in with the same username and password associated with your Gravatar account.

3. Fill in some details, including payment details if needed, and then click on **Finish**. You will then receive an e-mail with the API key. Keep this safe, as you should use it only on your sites.



4. Click on **Akismet**, which is located as a subitem of **Plugins** in your WordPress dashboard, and enter your Akismet key in the box on the screen. Check **Auto-delete spam submitted on posts more than a month old**, and then click on **Update Options**. The warning should now disappear and you should receive a message saying your key has been verified. Your forum's spam has been reduced, saving you time.

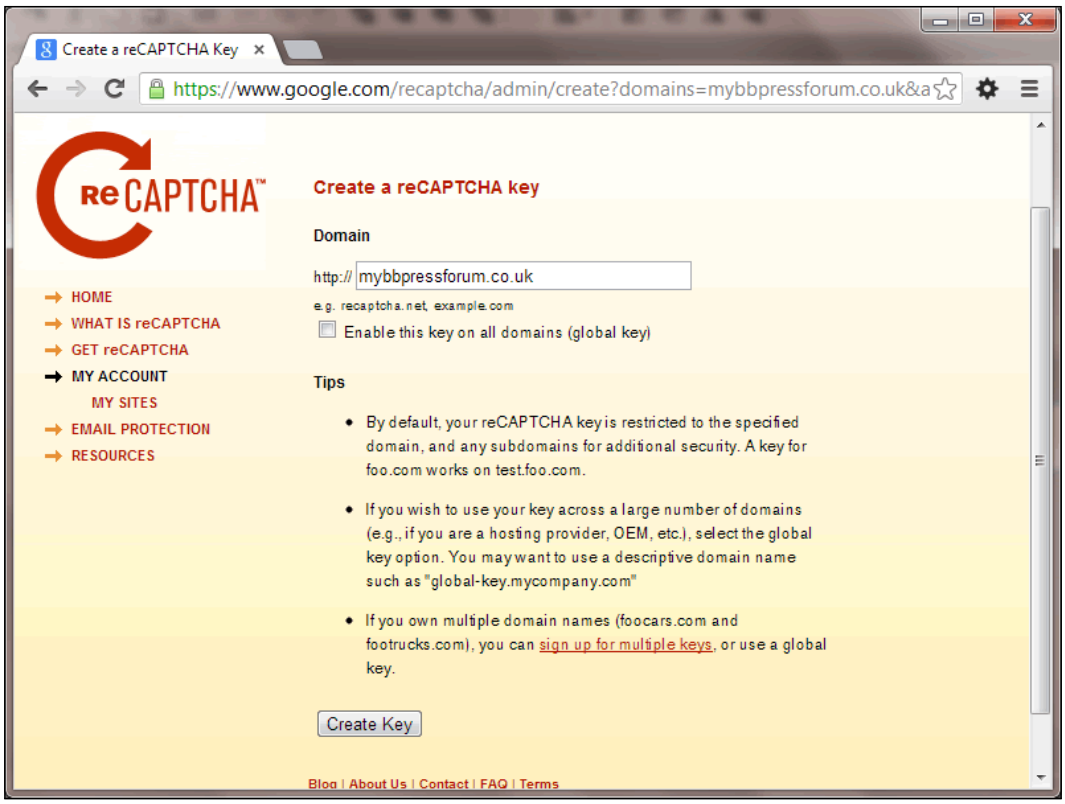
Blocking spam registrations – WP-reCAPTCHA

Blocking posts is fine, but even if they can't post, they can still register for your site. These accounts place links in their profile, which means that they could harm your site in the eyes of Google. Also, checking each profile and then removing all the links and blocking users can take time.

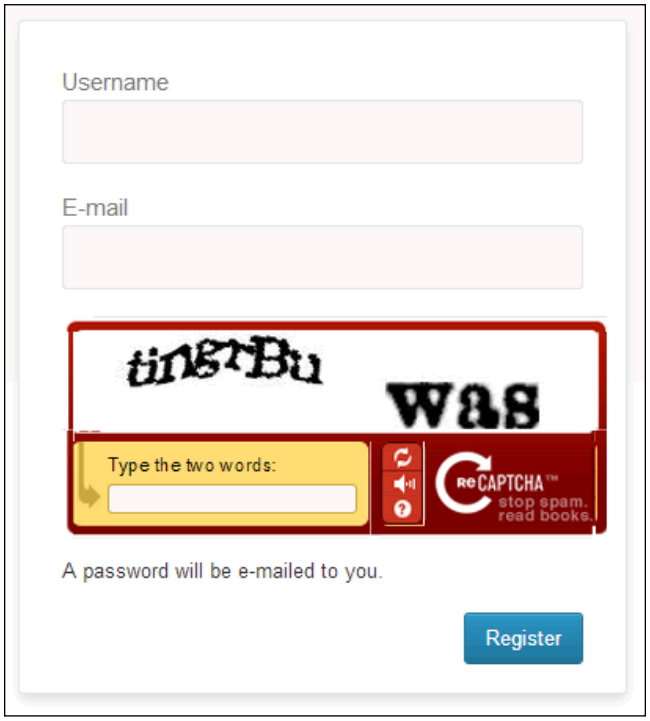
An easy way to block users signing up for spam accounts is to use WP-reCAPTCHA. This plugin uses the reCAPTCHA technology (a familiar sight for many Internet users) to block users who are unable to fill in an extra field (which many bots cannot). reCAPTCHA is a technology owned by Google and is free and relatively easy to set up.

The following are the steps to be performed for using the reCAPTCHA technology:

1. Search for `WP-reCAPTCHA` and install the one by *Jorge Pena* (it should be called **WP-reCAPTCHA**). Upon activation, its menu will appear as a submenu of **Settings**. Click on **WP-reCAPTCHA**, and a warning will appear as you need to enter your reCAPTCHA API keys.
2. To get your API keys, go to `https://www.google.com/recaptcha/admin/`, and then sign in to the site using your Google account. Click on **Add a New Site** and you should get a screen similar to the following screenshot:



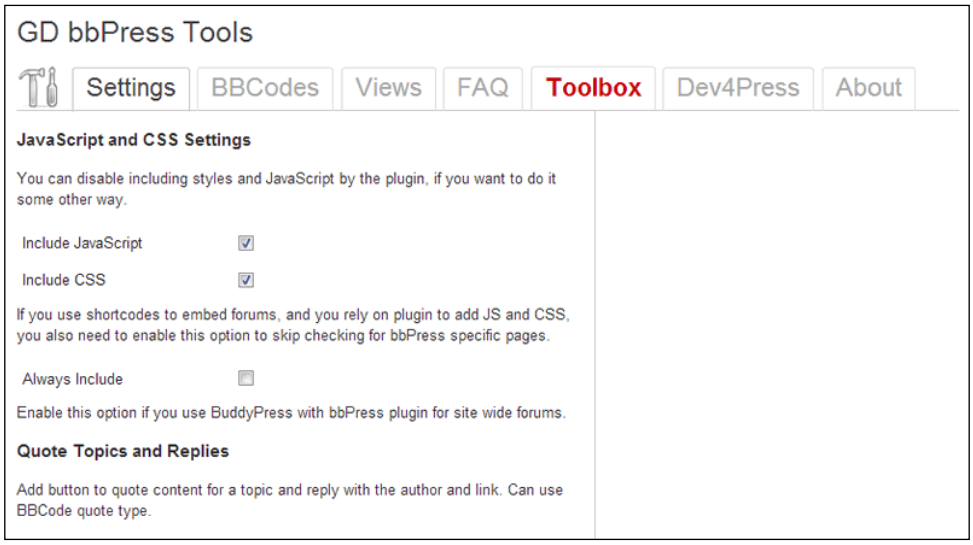
3. Fill in your domain and click on **Create Key**. You will be given a public key and a private key. Both keys should not be shared. Copy these to somewhere safe, and then return to the WP-reCAPTCHA options page and enter the public and private keys in the relevant boxes under authentication. Uncheck the **Enable form for Comments** option, unless you get a lot of spam comments, and then click on **Save reCAPTCHA Settings**.
4. The notification should now disappear, but you should check to see if the plugin is working. Log out of your site and go to your login URL and click on the **Register** button located at the bottom of the login page. You should see something that looks similar to the following screenshot:



GD bbPress Tools

One of the most advanced and useful plugins out there at the moment for bbPress is GD bbPress Tools. It does quite a lot to expand bbPress, so you should look at installing this now. Install it by searching for `GD bbPress Tools` to begin with.

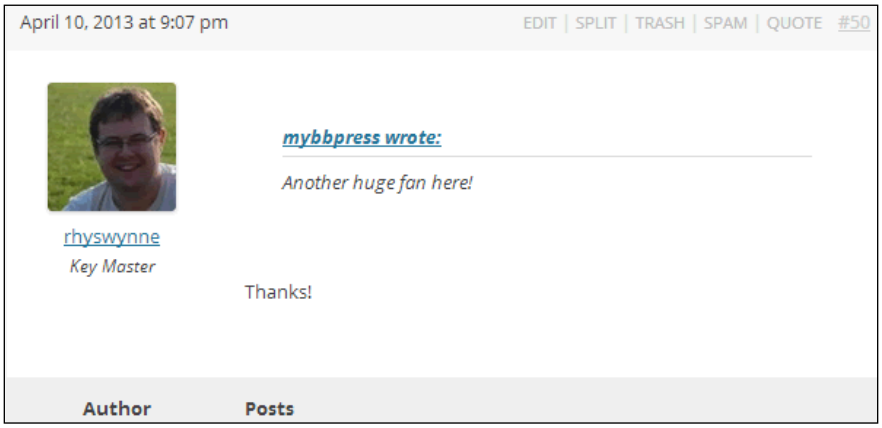
Click on the **Tools** submenu item, which is located beneath **Forums**, and you should see a large page of options as shown in the following screenshot:



You can leave the JavaScript and CSS settings checked, but here's what each major heading does, as well as any option that needs further explanation.

Quote Topics and Replies

The **Quote Topics and Replies** feature allows you to quote other member's posts. Quoting can be useful if you are referencing another member's post in your post because it helps aid discussion, as people can follow conversations very easily as shown in the following screenshot:



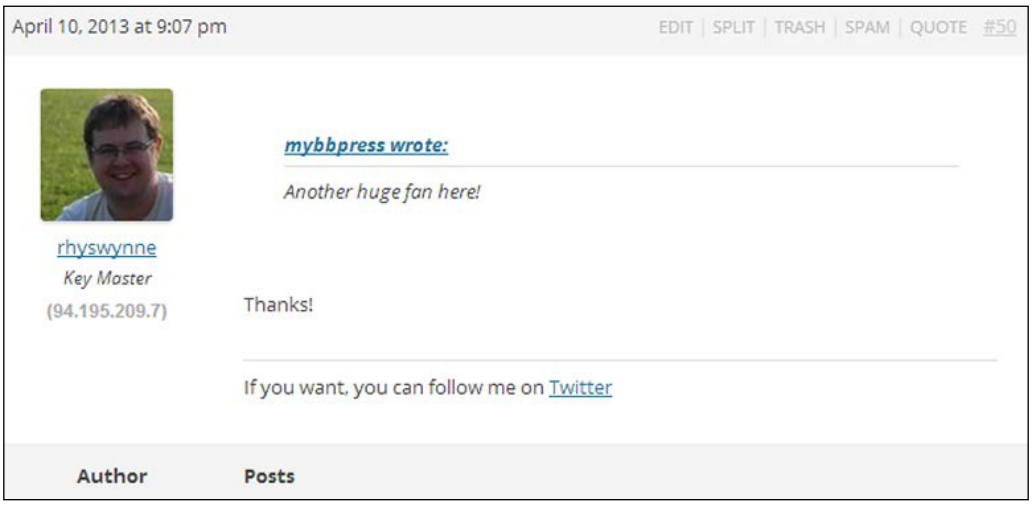
This section adds a button to the top bar, clearly seen in the preceding screenshot, to various user levels. By default this is switched on, located above all posts, and available to all users. There's no reason you should change any of this, as it adds a useful feature to your forum.

Toolbar Menu

The **Toolbar Menu** option adds on an item, **Forums**, to the top of the **Dashboard** toolbar, which shows up for logged in users. This gives users the ability to quickly access the forums from anywhere on the site, and can be activated for all users and is switched on by default. Again, there's no reason to turn this off.

User Signatures

The **User Signatures** option is split into two sections, and the result is the ability to display signatures beneath users' posts similar to the following screenshot:



The first set of options allows you to define the ability for each user level to create signatures and also how long the signature should be. 512 characters is the default, and in reality you shouldn't change this much, as we don't want large signatures that dominate the discussion.

The second set of options allows users to use either BBCode or HTML in their signatures, which will allow people to post images or links in their signatures. It's generally quite a good idea for security reasons to either set this to BBCode or disable this feature, as rogue HTML could affect the look of the forum. Also, if too many members post spam links in their footer, or show very large images, you can disable this so that only Moderators and Keymasters can have access to rich content in their signatures.

Limit bbPress access on admin side

The **Limit bbPress access on admin side** feature controls which users, dependent on their role, can see and access bbPress administration panels. For security reasons, leave this option switched off.

BBCodes

BBCodes is a universal forum notation for displaying rich content. By default, bbPress uses HTML via a rich text editor; however, if you have a large forum of experienced users, it could be worthwhile enabling BBCodes.

BBCodes uses slightly different notation than HTML using square brackets to display data. So for example, if you wish to display a link to Google with the anchor text "Google", you would use the following BBCode:

```
[url=http://www.google.com]Google[/url]
```

There are two reasons to use BBCode over HTML. First, it's slightly easier to use than HTML so can be useful for less technically advanced members. Secondly, it is slightly more secure than raw HTML; however, bbPress does strip out a lot of misformatted HTML.

In GD bbPress Tools, click on the **BBCodes** tab along the top of the screen, and you will be taken to the BBCodes option page. We will discuss each option individually and its recommended setting.

BBCodes support

The **BBCodes support** option switches on or off BBCode support throughout the site. By default it is switched on. If you don't wish for your forum to have BBCode support, uncheck this box.

BBCodes new topic/reply notice

The **BBCodes new topic/reply notice** option displays a notice above new posts and replies informing users that they can post BBCodes to format their content. There really isn't much more to add to this, and it's entirely up to you whether you display this message or not.

However, one issue is that the message displayed in the following screenshot isn't exactly the most helpful:

Therefore, it's a good idea to create a page on your site with a list of the BBCodes you can use. A list is available on this option page to the right of the screen.

Limit to bbPress only

The **Limit to bbPress only** option, when checked, allows BBCodes to be used throughout the site (for example, in comments). Generally it's a bad idea to add BBCodes to comment forms, as it increases the success rate of spambots, so leave this unchecked.

Advanced BBCodes

The **Advanced BBCodes** option allows you to set the user level in which advanced BBCodes (such as URL, YouTube, Vimeo, Google, Image, and Note) are used on the site. Generally I'd leave this, since here, every user level can post all types of content; however, if it becomes unmanageable, you can set this so that only Moderators and Keymasters can post rich content.

Views

GD bbPress Tools also adds on a couple of **Views** pages. These are useful when building out your forum and integrating it with your bbPress theme, as these provide a customized list of posts that you can place within your theme.

To access the views settings on the GD bbPress Tools option page, click the **Views** tab located along the top.

The following are the views you can edit:

- **Topics With The Most Replies**: This is the list of the most popular topics on the forum sorted by those with the most replies.
- **Topics Search**: This page is the search results page. A widget is added to bbPress, which we will discuss later, and it allows you to search topics. This view is the search results page.
- **Latest Topics**: This will show all the latest topics on the forum, organized by date, with the latest first.

There is really no reason whatsoever to switch any of these off, so leave these options checked.

> In addition to the three views you can switch on and off, there is another view added, **Topics With No Replies**, which will allow you to view all the topics with no replies. It's a good idea when growing the forum to answer all topics, so this can help you find unanswered topics and reply to them.

Attachments – GD bbPress attachments

On some forums, you can upload attachments to posts allowing you to share extra information to registered users (such as an image or a text file). It's not for every forum, but for some forums, you may wish for users to upload attachments.

Luckily there's a plugin called GD bbPress attachments that handles this—the safest and the most secure of every plugin I've seen—as it uses WordPress' inbuilt media uploader to manage the attachments. To install this plugin, search for `GD bbPress Attachments` in the plugin library. When installed, go to the **Attachments** page located as a submenu of **Forums**. When visited, there's quite a large **Settings** page that does need setting up before using the plugin.

Global Attachment Settings

The **Global Attachment Settings** section allows you to set up the global attachment settings for the forum. These settings apply to all uploads, no matter the type or the location.

Maximum File Size

Maximum File Size allows you to set the maximum file size of each upload. By default, each upload is half a megabyte (512 KB) in size. It's quite a good idea to leave this the same, as it prevents people from uploading huge files, such as unoptimized photos. Each uploaded file contributes to your limit on your site, so be careful.

Maximum Files To Upload

The **Maximum Files To Upload** option allows you to set the maximum number of files to upload per topic or reply. By default, the most files you can upload is four.

> I would consider dropping the number of files people can upload to one or two, especially for busy forums.

Hide The List Of Attached Files From Visitors

The **Hide The List Of Attached Files From Visitors** option helps you to hide the list of files attached to each post by visitors. By default, the box is checked, and I recommend you keep it checked. Visitors accessing files could at best increase your bandwidth costs, or at worse access sensitive information uploaded by native users.

Users Upload Restrictions

The **Users Upload Restrictions** option sets the user level, where the **Upload** option will be displayed. Depending on the forum, you may wish that only Moderators or Keymasters have access to the **Upload** option. If this isn't the case, it's a good idea to leave this option the same.

Topic and Reply Deleting

Topic and Reply Deleting sets the fate of uploaded files if their parent topic or reply is deleted. By default, they are set to be left in the media library. I'd recommend that to save space, they should be deleted. You can select **Do Nothing**, which deletes a post, yet leaves the attachment present on the post. I don't recommend this option.

JavaScript and CSS Settings

This **JavaScript and CSS Settings** option allows you to disable JavaScript and CSS for styling attachments. This should only be unchecked if you want to include the site's JavaScript or CSS anyway; however, I'd recommend leaving these checked.

If you are embedding your forum elsewhere on your site, I'd also recommend checking the box below, which will enable JavaScript and CSS on all pages (not just bbPress forums).

Error Logging

Error Logging allows you to log upload errors. This can be useful for troubleshooting upload issues that the users have. There's no reason to switch these options off, unless the forum becomes so big and bloated with people making errors and uploading these errors that it becomes troublesome. Most forums should leave these settings on though.

Deleting Attachments

The **Deleting Attachments** settings allow you to delete and detach attachments. Deleting removes them completely from the site, and detaching removes them from the topic or reply yet leaves them in the media library. You can choose whether Keymasters, Moderators, or post authors have this option.

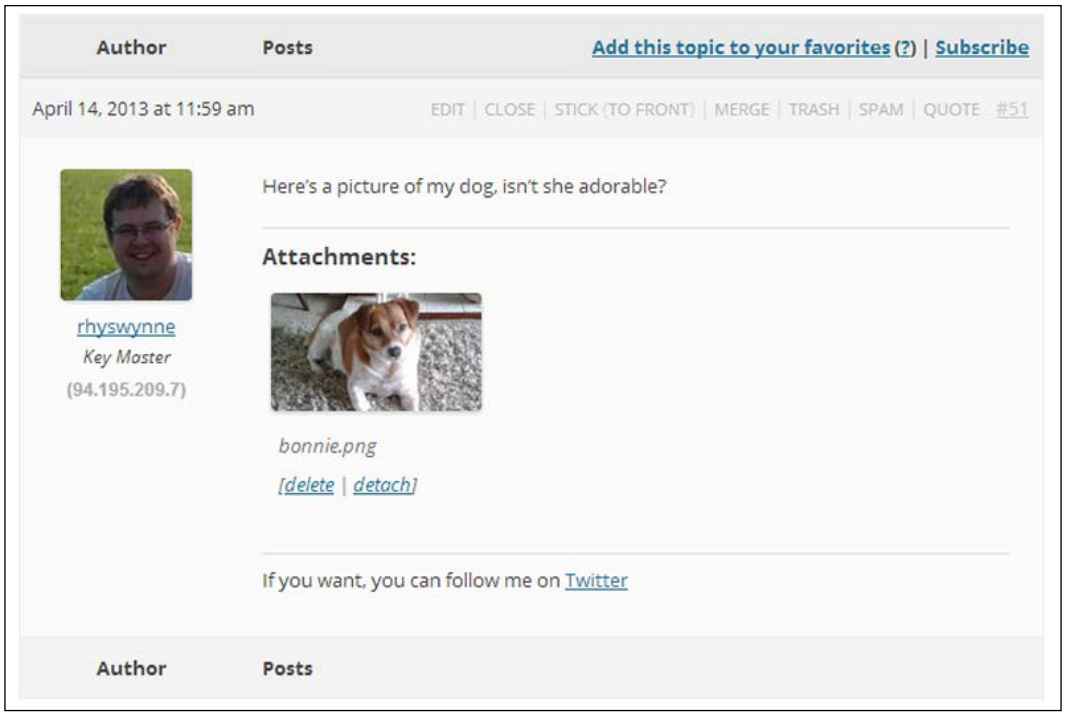
I recommend allowing Keymasters and Moderators to have the ability to delete and detach, and authors only have the ability to detach. Giving authors "delete" capabilities could be troublesome, but allowing them to detach files can't cause harm.

Forums Integration

The **Forums Integration** option allows you to display icons for common file types that aren't images. To aid usability, I'd recommend keeping these options switched on.

Display of Image Attachments

Rather than display icons for image attachments, you can display images as thumbnails. If you activate this, you will see a thumbnail of the image beneath the forum post as shown in the following screenshot:



I recommend activating this but hiding the caption (as you can see in my picture, the "caption" is the filename). You can give this a CSS class to give some CSS styling to the image, and give it a `REL` attribute. By default, the `REL` attribute is `lightbox`. If you have a jQuery lightbox plugin activated on the site (for example "jQuerylightbox"), you will be able to get the image to open in a lightbox window when clicked.

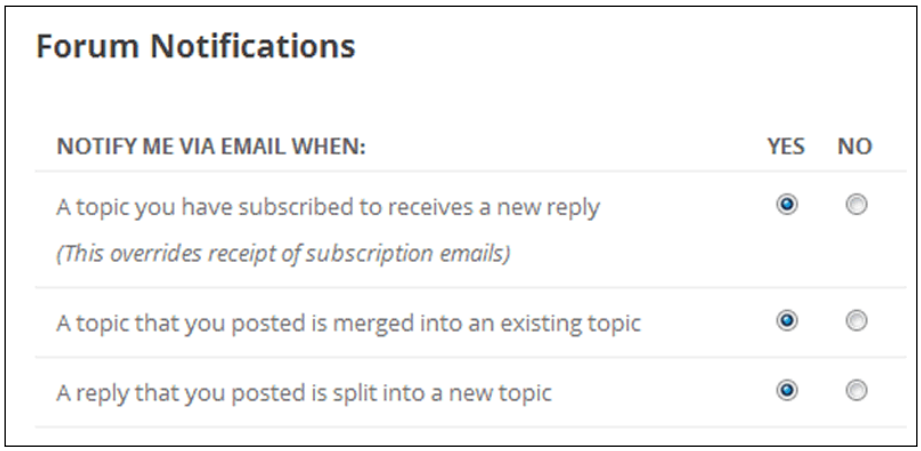
Image Thumbnails Size

The **Image Thumbnails Size** option will change the thumbnail size of the image located beneath the post. It is recommended that though you set this to a size when you first launch the forum, and never change this, to keep this uniform throughout the site.

Improved e-mail notifications – bbPress Email Notifications

Although without any plugins, bbPress does provide pretty good e-mail notifications; it is missing quite a lot of functionality, particularly when it comes to merge and split topics. To rectify this, search for and install the bbPress Email Notifications in the WordPress plugin repository.

This plugin requires no setup, but adds on a section within the user's profile page that allows you to set up whether or not they should receive e-mail notifications from the forum as shown in the following screenshot:



These settings are only for one user rather than for all users, so users subscribed to topics can disable e-mails using this plugin. This is useful for busy forums, so well worth installing.

Viewing unread topics – bbPress unread posts

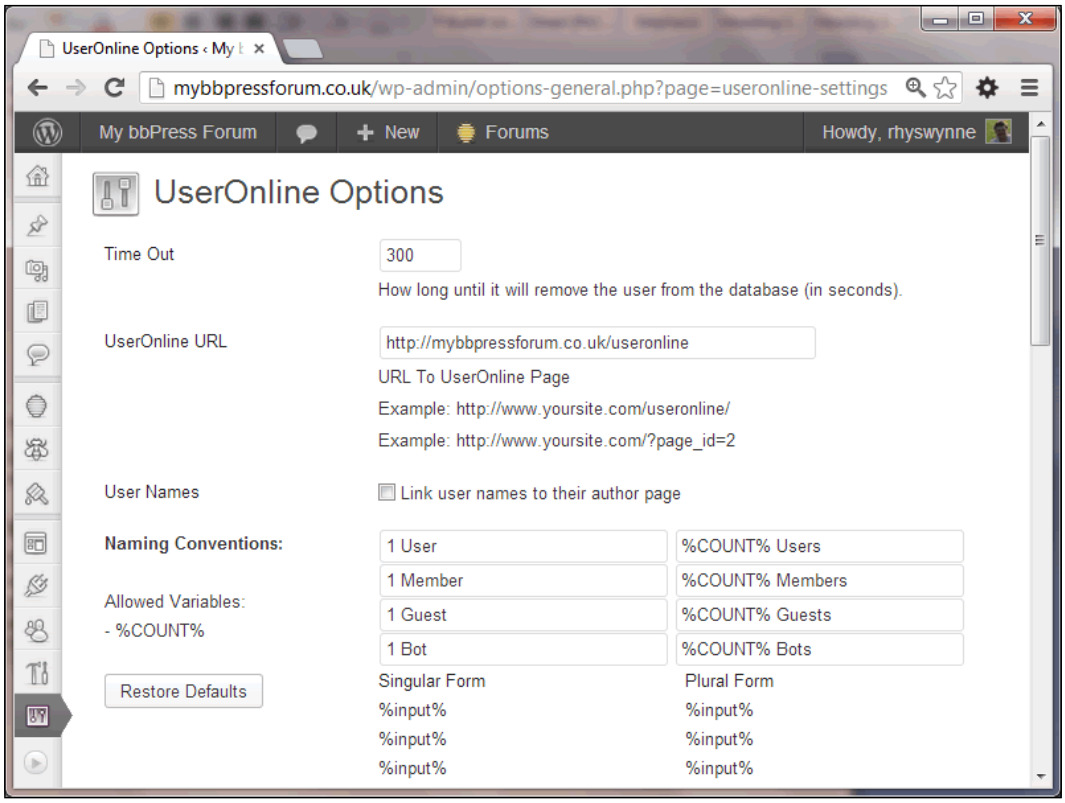
On many forums, you will be able to see topics with unread replies allowing users to browse their forum more quickly and easily than normal. Thankfully, there are lots of plugins out there with lots of different functionalities on how to display unread topics. A personal favorite of mine is bbPress unread posts. Search for `bbPress Unread Posts` in the WordPress plugin repository and install it.

There is no setup for this plugin, and when installed, an icon next to each of the posts will be displayed. The icon will change depending on whether you have read all the replies in that topic or not, as shown in the following screenshot:

Beneath the forums, as you can see in the screenshot, there is a **Mark all topics as Read** button. Clicking this marks all the topics in the forum as read, saving time.

View users online – WP-UserOnline

For busy forums, it can be great to see the users who are currently online. Having a list of users currently online can help generate more topics and replies, as users can see other people logged on and browsing the forum at the same time, and therefore could post more. A good plugin to use for this is actually a WordPress plugin, WP-UserOnline. Search and install `WP-UserOnline` from the WordPress plugin repository and visit the **UserOnline Settings** page located under the **Settings** menu.



Here are each of the options and their values. By default, the plugin is set up perfectly for our forum, but here's what each option does.

Time Out

Time Out displays how long a user appears in the **UsersOnline Options** page without any changes before they are removed. By default it's 300 seconds; I recommend using this.

UserOnline URL

If you create a blank page, you can create a page that will display the current users online. As most of the time we will be using the `Widget` function to display the users online, we don't really need to worry about this URL.

Link User Names To Their Author Page

The **Link User Names To Their Author Page** option needs to be unchecked for bbPress. Very few, if any of the users of your site will be authors, so this will lead to a lot of blank pages. It's far easier to leave this unchecked.

Naming Conventions / UserOnline Templates

The **Naming Conventions/UserOnline Templates** settings are aimed at how to display the user lists on the site. By default the language used is English, so if you are creating a foreign language site, you may wish to change this.

This page uses a lot of variables that are replaced with text. Here is the list of the variables used and what it is replaced with on the site:

Variable	Explanation
`%COUNT%`	Displays the number of users, guests, or bots on the site
`%USERS%`	This variable displays the total number of users, guests, and bots on the site
`%PAGE_URL%`	This variable displays the URL to the **UsersOnline** page
`%MOSTONLINE_COUNT%`	This variable displays the total number of the most frequent users, guests, and bots online
`%MOSTONLINE_DATE%`	The date when most of the regular users, guests, and bots were online
`%MEMBERS%`	Displays the members' text (by default `%COUNT% Members`)
`%MEMBER_NAMES%`	The display name of all members, separated by a comma by default
`%GUESTS_SEPARATOR%`	The separator associated with guests, default comma
`%GUESTS%`	Displays the guests' text (defined earlier in the page – the default is `%COUNT% Guests`)
`%BOTS_SEPARATOR%`	The separator associated with bots, default comma
`%BOTS%`	Displays the bots' text (defined earlier in the page – the default is `%COUNT% Bots`)

If you are not using a UserOnline URL for a separate page, remove the link from the Users Online template. The following code explains how to do this before removing the link:

```
<a href="%PAGE_URL%"><strong>%USERS%</strong> Online</a>
```

In order to remove the link, change the preceding code to the following code:

```
<strong>%USERS%</strong> Online
```

Plugin checks – what to look for when installing plugins?

Although plugins are great in expanding the functionality of blogs, unfortunately it stands to reason that the more number of plugins you install on your website, the more likely you develop issues on your site.

With WordPress (and therefore bbPress) being open source, the beauty is that although plugins and themes can be developed by everybody, somebody has probably made a plugin with what you want to do. Unfortunately, because plugins can be developed by everybody, and not everybody may adhere to the strictest guidelines, they may develop issues.

Issues can take a multitude of forms, but the following are the most common key issues:

- The plugin causes conflicts. This happens because of poor coding on the part of one of the plugin's coders, and it conflicts with another plugin or with WordPress itself.
- The plugin is depreciated. This means that the plugin's author doesn't support the plugin anymore, and as such WordPress may have changed a function that the plugin uses or is no longer within WordPress (this can cause errors).

They are the two main issues that strike many plugins. There are occasional cases whereby the plugin has fallen into malicious hands, but generally the community is great at dealing with this sort of issue and removing malicious plugins.

However for the other two issues, you are unlikely to get much support, and as such you need to rely on your own judgement. Here are a few questions you can ask yourself before installing a plugin to your site.

Question 1 – when was the plugin last updated?

When you view a potential plugin on `WordPress.org` through a Google search, you can see when the plugin was last updated. Generally this is a good indication of how well the plugin is supported. The plugins that are most supported are updated to work with the latest version before the latest version is usually released, and many plugins are updated after a version is released; it's only when the plugin's author has lost interest and it is no longer updated when this can be dangerous.

Some plugins actively state they are no longer being updated, but down the right-hand side of the plugin page (for example, `http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/incomment-referrer/`), you can see the date the plugin was last updated. Furthermore, on plugins that are not updated since last two years, you get the following notification:

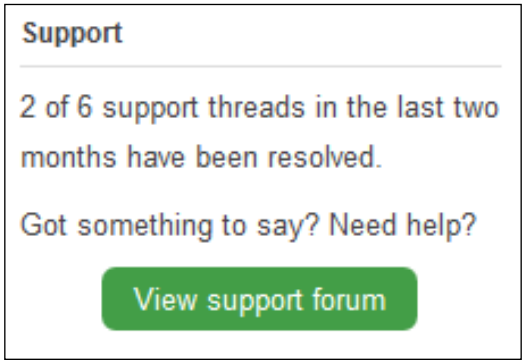
> This plugin **hasn't been updated in over 2 years**. It may no longer be maintained or supported and may have compatibility issues when used with more recent versions of WordPress.

Generally try to avoid installing the plugins that are over two years old since their last update, as WordPress generally operates on about 3 to 4 month development cycles. So these plugins were in all likelihood tested on versions that are between 6 and 8 versions behind the current ones.

> Plugins that are over two years old do not appear in any of WordPress' internal plugin searches.

Question 2 – how well is the plugin supported?

Beneath the plugin's author details, in the right-hand column, is the **Support** section; the following screenshot gives you an idea of how active the support is on each plugin:

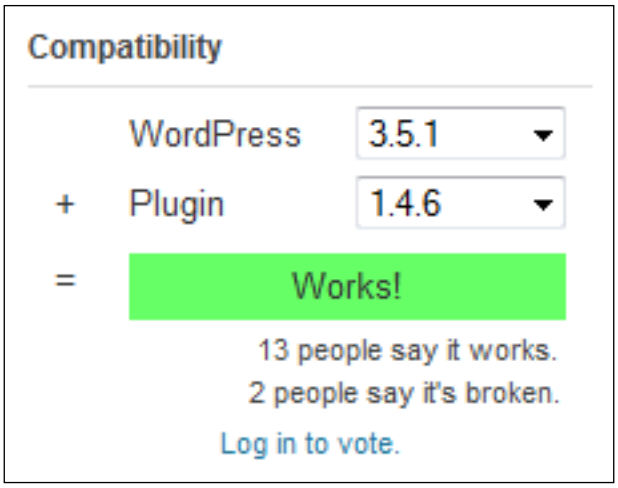


Authors of plugins can mark threads as being resolved, and as such you can see how active the author is at fixing faults with the plugin. An actively supported plugin generally means you will have fewer problems with it.

> You are able to release a plugin into the community unsupported if it's specified, or you can also offer paid support. As such, this question should be asked in conjunction with other questions, rather than on its own.

Question 3 – does the community say it works?

The bottom box in the right-hand column contains anonymous community feedback on whether a plugin works or not. Quite simply, if the plugin either says **Works!** (as shown in the following screenshot), or there's inconclusive data, it's worth trying:



This requires quite a lot of data to work, and as such, many plugins have **Inconclusive** or **No Data** as an answer. Nevertheless, it can be worth checking particularly for popular plugins.

Question 4 – anything incriminating on search engines?

Probably one of the best things you can do is search for the plugin in a search engine. Generally, security issues or anything that breaks it usually results in a blog post appearing online from a disgruntled individual or a support thread on a forum. Try searching for the plugin name before installation.

Please don't let this section put you off from installing plugins. The majority of WordPress and bbPress plugins adhere to high coding standards and very rarely things go wrong; however, just be aware that such issues can happen. If they do happen with your site, log in to the FTP area of your site, and then delete the offending plugin and your site will return to its previous state without any issues.

Actions and filters – developing your own bbPress plugins!

Still cannot find a solution to your issue? Want to get your hands dirty and fix an issue in someone else's plugin? Why not create your own plugin. Creating your own plugin, which is not only beneficial for the community, but can also have a positive effect on yourself, as it can lead to opportunities and help stake a claim for yourself in a great community.

As bbPress plugin development is an offshoot of WordPress plugin development, it is beyond the scope of this book. Check out *WordPress Plugin Development: A Beginners Guide*, *Vladamir Prelovac*, *Packt Publishing* at `http://www.packtpub.com/wordpress-plug-in-development/` for more in-depth information on developing WordPress plugins. However, we can cover some basics of plugin development, which anybody with a rudimentary knowledge of PHP should be familiar with.

Before beginning WordPress Plugin Development, please read the *WordPress Coding Standards* located at `http://codex.wordpress.org/WordPress_Coding_Standards`; by doing so, you'll ensure that your plugin causes as little conflict as possible.

bbPress API – actions and functions

bbPress API has two features to it: actions and functions.

- **Actions**: These are the series of functions that are run at certain times during a page's execution. You can add your functions into these actions. These are used by template designers so that instead of repeating lines of code (for example, say the display of the author's name and Gravatar), they use one line of code.
- **Functions**: These are the pieces of code that allow you to do a certain task by using one line of code. bbPress functions allow you to interact with the bbPress page in question and also the database very easily.

Adding your plugin's function to bbPress using action hooks

Suppose you have written a function called `my_bbpress_function`, and you want it to run before the forum description is displayed on the page. As such, you use the following code to run this:

```
add_action('bbp_theme_before_forum_description', 'my_bbpress_
function', $priority,$accepted_args );
```

The `add_action` call tells WordPress that the `my_bbpress_function` function is to be run whenever `bbp_theme_before_description` is run. Two optional variables are included in the call as well. `$priority` is a number in which the priority of the function is run in ascending numerical order (so a function with priority `1` is ran before a function with priority `10`), and `$accepted_args` allows you to specify the amount of accepted arguments that are included in the function (so if your function is defined with two arguments, your `$accepted_args` must be set to `2`)

Common bbPress API actions

Action Reference	Action Description
`bbp_theme_after_topic_author`	Displays content after the author's avatar and name in a forum
`bbp_theme_before_topic_author`	Displays content before the author's avatar and name in a forum
`bbp_theme_after_forum_freshness_link`	Displays content after the forum freshness link on a list of forums
`bbp_theme_before_forum_freshness_link`	Displays content before the forum freshness link on a list of forums
`bbp_forum_row_actions`	Displays content within the administrative rows above forums on the forum display screen
`bbp_theme_after_forum_description`	Displays content after the description of the forum on forum index pages
`bbp_theme_before_forum_description`	Displays content before the description of the forum on forum index pages
`bbp_theme_after_forum_sub_forums`	Displays content after each list of subforum links

Action Reference	Action Description
`bbp_theme_before_forum_sub_forums`	Displays content before each list of subforum links
`bbp_theme_before_forum_title`	Displays content before each forum title on the forum index pages

Common bbPress API functions

Apart from actions, bbPress has a range of API functions as well. Functions allow developers to interact with the bbPress database without having to write their own functions.

The following table details the most common API functions. Before writing a function from scratch, check the following table to see if a similar function already exists:

Function Reference	Function Description
`bbp_author_link`	Displays the most recently active author's avatar and username linked to their profile
`bbp_get_forum_freshness_link`	Returns the link for the most recent reply within a forum
`bbp_forum_freshness_link`	Displays the link for the most recent reply within a forum
`bbp_get_forum_post_count`	Returns the total count of all replies to topics within a forum and subforums
`bbp_forum_post_count`	Displays the total count of all replies to topics within a forum and subforums
`bbp_get_forum_reply_count`	Returns the total count of all replies to topics within a forum and subforums
`bbp_forum_reply_count`	Displays the total count of all replies to topics within a forum and subforums
`bbp_show_lead_topic`	Uses an alternate layout style where topics appear as "lead" posts ahead of replies, whereas default topics are included in the reply loop
`bp_get_forum_last_active_id`	Returns the ID of the most recent reply within a forum
`bbp_forum_last_active_id`	Displays the ID of the most recently active forum

The preceding descriptions and references are taken from the *bbPress Codex*, which has full examples on how each action should be used. This codex is updated more often than this book, and you can see it at `http://codex.bbpress.org`.

Summary

By now, you should have a great, feature-rich forum and may even be interested in developing your own bbPress plugins. I strongly encourage you to do so, even if it is a case of releasing some code designed for your forum or possibly a client out in the public domain. This community, that I have been a part of, is one of the most wholesome and friendly communities, and has also led me to some great opportunities including writing this book that you are reading.

Even though the functionality is great, your forum may appear a little disjointed with the rest of your site. However, we will look into integrating your forum into your theme in the next and final chapter.

5
Adding bbPress to Your WordPress Theme

Everything in this book until now has been focused on functions in WordPress. We have learned various ways of making bbPress work and making it work well; however, the Internet is a visual tool, and as such to help present the information and help sell your forum to new members, it needs to look good.

This chapter will talk about adding style to your substance. bbPress uses WordPress themes, so we will look at how to integrate your theme with bbPress and examine each of the ways in which you can get your theme to display bbPress content. We will cover the following topics in this chapter:

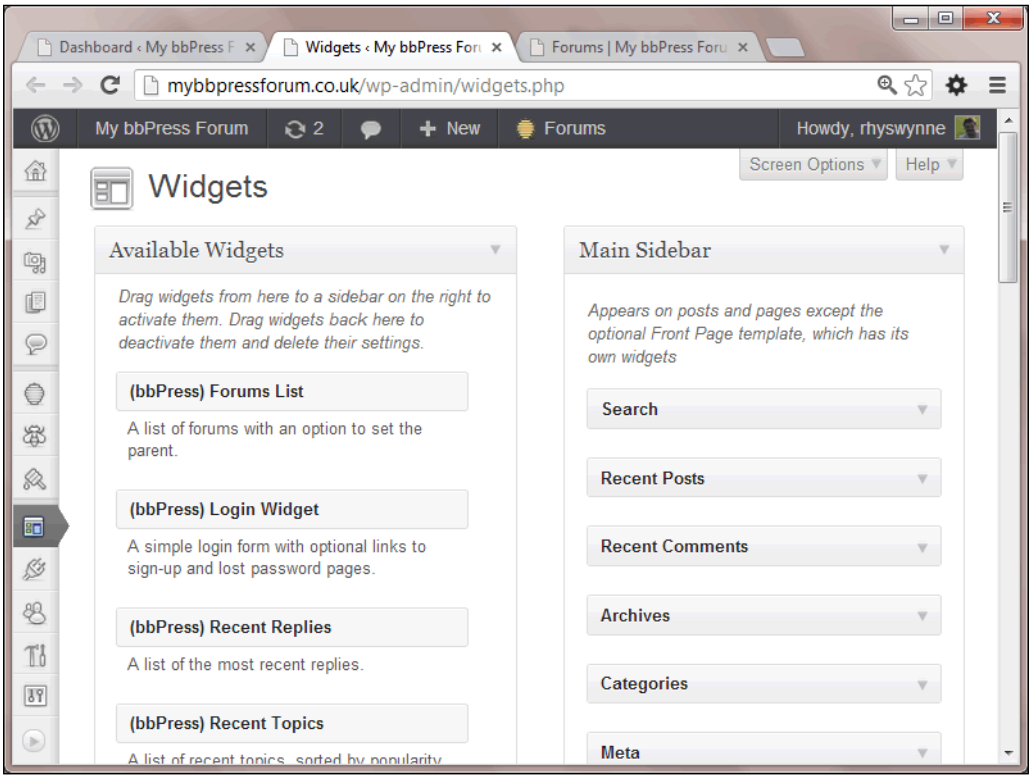
- How to add bbPress widgets to your WordPress sidebar, as well as an explanation of each bbPress widget and how to add more
- The bbPress (and WordPress) template structure, and how it works
- How to make your template bbPress ready, and showing your visitors your forum for the first time
- How to create a forum-specific sidebar for your theme, which shows different content on the blog

By the end of this chapter, you'll have a complete understanding of bbPress's template structure and be confident to make changes to your site to make it look great. Your forum will be fully integrated with the rest of your site, and you can begin running your forum and promoting it.

Adding bbPress widgets to WordPress

WordPress uses a widget system to display sidebar content. **Widgets** allow users to add content and information to sidebars easily using a drag-and-drop system. Therefore, any user that has no experience in coding can easily change the look of a widget-enabled template without much work. Although traditionally used in sidebars, template designers can add widgets anywhere they please (something we will do later in this chapter).

To add widgets to WordPress, within the WordPress dashboard, click on **Widgets**, which is a submenu of the **Appearance** tab. You will see a screen similar to the following screenshot:

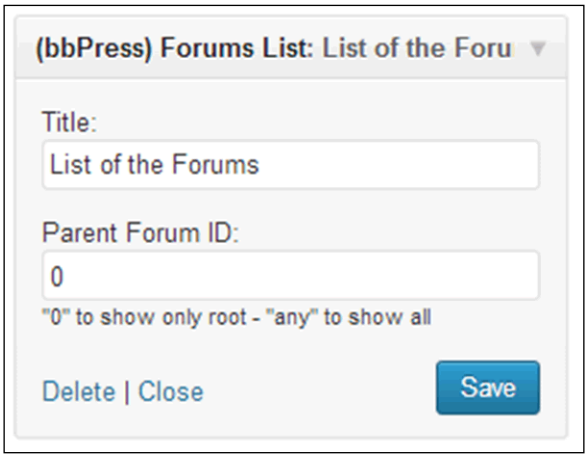


On the left-hand side of the screen, you will see the **Available Widgets** box. This box contains all the widgets that are currently installed and available to be used, either installed by plugins or by the theme itself. The right-hand side of the screen will have all the "widgetized" areas of your WordPress site. Good theme developers will give a short description above each widgetized area, but others may not. Either way, it should be fairly clear where the widget is located by the name of it.

To install a widget, drag the widget from the left-hand column to the right-hand one.

Having problems accessing and modifying widgets? If you click on **Screen Options** (located in the top right-hand corner of the screen) and click on **Enable Accessibility Mode**, you will be able to use a more accessible menu system for creating widgets, which is compatible with all devices.

If present, there may be options associated with each widget, shown as follows:



Fill in these options if present and then click on **Save** to save the widget. Check your site and your widget should be present on the site.

You can now drag the widget in order to reorder it in the sidebar, or click on its title to open or close the options for that widget.

To delete a widget, click on the **Delete** option located in the bottom left-hand corner of the widget. This deletes *everything* associated with the widget, so be careful. A much safer option is to make the widget inactive. This removes it from the display area but keeps the settings intact.

To make the widget inactive, there is a box beneath **Available Widgets** on the left-hand side of the screen called **Inactive Widgets**. Drag the widget you want into this box to disable it. This will save the widget for a later date should you need to reactivate it.

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Available bbPress widgets

bbPress comes with a number of widgets preinstalled. Here is what each widget does, and their options:

- **(bbPress) Forums List**: This adds on a list of forums to the sidebar. You can define a title for this widget, as well as define what forums are present. If you leave the default option, **0**, the list will show only the parent forums and no subforums. Giving a forum ID number will display only that forum and any subforum of that forum. Typing `any` will show all forums.
- **(bbPress) Login Widget**: This will present a login widget and basic information if logged in. Like many other WordPress widgets, you can give a title, but you also need to provide a Register URI and a Lost Password URI. If unsure what to put here, place the following values (replacing `mybbpressdomain.com` with your domain name):
    - Register URI: `http://mybbpressdomain.com/wp-login.php?action=register`
    - Lost Password URI: `http://mybbpressdomain.com/wp-login.php?action=lostpassword`
- **(bbPress) Recent Replies**: This shows the most recent replies to the forum. You can specify a title as well as the number of replies to show, and also if you want to show the post date and author name.
- **(bbPress) Recent Topics**: This displays the most recent topics on the forum. You can specify a title, the number of topics to show, if the post's date and author are shown, and the order of the topics that are displayed.
- **(bbPress) Topic Views**: This allows you to display some preset views for the forum. These views are topics with no replies, topics with the most replies, the latest topics, and the search results.

Adding more widgets with GD bbPress widgets

There is a useful plugin called GD bbPress widgets that is worth installing, which you can do by searching and installing **GD bbPress widgets** from the plugin repository. It adds the following two widgets to bbPress:

- **bbPress: Search Topics**: This adds on a search field that allows you to search the forums. This is better than the default search field included in WordPress, as it searches the forum exclusively (rather than the topics, replies, posts, and pages). You can give it a title, as well as display this to everybody, or only users or visitors.

- **bbPress: Topics Views**: This is very similar to the default Topics Views that is provided with bbPress. However, this will allow you to choose which topic views to display, and who to display them to.

I do recommend this version of Topics Views over the one that is included in bbPress, as you have more control; the Search Topics Views, for example, is almost completely redundant in the sidebar.

The bbPress (and WordPress) template structure

WordPress follows quite a simple principle for templating. In short, the minimum number of files needed to run a template is two, the `index.php` and `style.css` files. However, you can add on a number of template files so that individual pages or posts can have their own style. If a template file isn't present, WordPress reverts to the previous file in the template hierarchy; a full guide to the template hierarchy can be seen at `http://codex.wordpress.org/Template_Hierarchy`.

bbPress follows a similar structure, and up until now you probably haven't played much with the template yet still seen the forums. The reason is that bbPress not only follows its own template structure but also integrates into WordPress's structure.

Should you wish to change the templates in bbPress, there are five files that bbPress accesses; they are presented here in order of importance:

- `forum.php`: This template is used for each individual forum
- `forums.php`: This template is used for all forum pages, be it individual (if `forum.php` isn't present) or a list of forums
- `bbpress.php`: This template is used for all bbPress pages when any of the previous two aren't present, as well as pages such as profile pages or login screens
- `page.php`: This template is used for all WordPress pages generated by bbPress or by another plugin or created by the user
- `index.php`: This template is the default template used by WordPress posts, pages, categories, and any post type or taxonomy

The templates work in descending order, so if `forum.php` isn't present, each individual forum will revert to `forums.php`; if that isn't present, the template file used for individual forums will be `bbpress.php`; and so on.

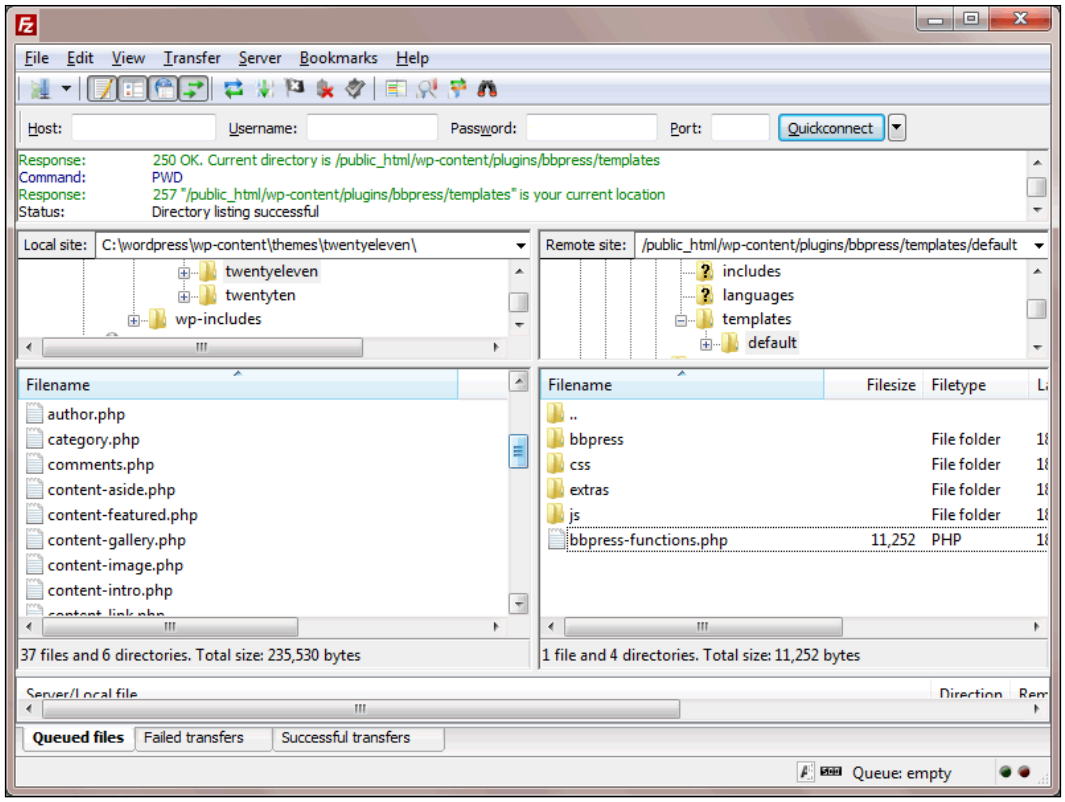
Should your theme not have any of these files (most won't), you need to create them. In FTP, visit your theme's folder (located at `/wp-content/themes/[theme-name]/`) and find a file called `page.php`. Almost all themes have this file; if not, use `index.php`. Copy this file and save it as either `forum.php`, `forums.php`, or `bbpress.php` in the same location as `page.php`. WordPress will then recognize these files as being bbPress files, and use these rather than WordPress files to display the forum.

Editing individual elements of bbPress

Apart from editing the templates, you can also edit individual elements of the forum. These elements help display the forum and various elements are used on every page in bbPress. These adhere to a different template hierarchy to WordPress, in that if any of the files are not present, the file located at `/wp-content/plugins/bbPress/templates/default/` is used.

Adding individual elements of bbPress to your theme

Should you wish to edit any of these files, the best and most secure way is by adding these files to your theme. To do this, log in to your FTP folder and navigate to your folder at `/wp-content/plugins/bbPress/templates/default/` on the remote view, and also to the root of your template in the local view.



Copy the entire contents of the template folder to the root of your template folder, leaving the files in `bbpress/templates/default` intact.

bbPress will now use the files within your template to render the individual elements of these items. Should they not be present, the corresponding file located in the default folder of bbPress is used.

Individual bbPress elements and their functions

The bbPress template files, now residing in your theme's folder (as stated before), all do a different task. The following list of templates will help you locate the template you wish to edit to change the look of your site.

- **Page templates**: These templates control the look of entire pages and are often made up of smaller templates. The following is a list of page-level templates:

File name	Function
`/bbpress/content-archive-forum.php`	This template is used whenever a list of forums is displayed.
`/bbpress/content-archive-topic.php`	This template is used whenever a list of topics is displayed that isn't part of a forum (such as a view, search results, or tag archive).
`/bbpress/content-single-forum.php`	This template is shown whenever a single forum is displayed.
`/bbpress/content-single-reply.php`	This is the template used for a single reply. It is not usually used by the forum, but can be used by the shortcode `[bbp-single-reply]` (shortcodes will be discussed later).
`/bbpress/content-single-topic-lead.php`	This template is shown if you wish to style the topic starter in a different manner to the style of replies.
`/bbpress/content-single-topic.php`	This template is shown when a single topic is displayed using the shortcode `[bbp-single-topic id=$topic_id]`.
`/bbpress/content-single-user.php`	This template is used whenever a user's page is displayed.
`/bbpress/content-single-view.php`	This template is used whenever a view is displayed using the shortcode `[bbp-single-view]`.
`/bbpress/content-topic-tag-edit.php`	This template is used when a tag edit page is displayed.
`/bbpress/user-details.php`	This is the template used to display any user page, such as a profile page or a list-of-topics-created page.

File name	Function
`/bbpress/user-favorites.php`	This is the template used to display a user's favourite topics.
`/bbpress/user-profile.php`	This is the template used to display a user's profile.
`/bbpress/user-replies-created.php`	This is the template used to display all the replies a user has created.
`/bbpress/user-subscriptions.php`	This is the template used to display the user's subscriptions.
`/bbpress/user-topics-created.php`	This is the template used to display all replies a user has created.

- **Feedback templates**: These templates are how universal messages are displayed on the site, and generally appear on one or many of the preceding page templates. The following is a list of feedback templates:

File name	Function
`/bbpress/feedback-logged-in.php`	This template is used to display the **You are already logged in** notice.
`/bbpress/feedback-no-access.php`	This template is used to display the **You do not have permission to view this forum** notice.
`/bbpress/feedback-no-forums.php`	This template is used to display the **Oh bother! No forums were found here!** notice.
`/bbpress/feedback-no-replies.php`	This template is used to display the **Oh bother! No replies were found here!** notice.
`/bbpress/feedback-no-topics.php`	This template is used to display the **Oh bother! No topics were found here!** notice.

- **Form templates**: These templates are used whenever a form is shown on the screen. The following is a list of form templates:

Filename	Function
`/bbpress/form-anonymous.php`	This template is used to display the form fields displayed above the post if you have anonymous posting switched on.
`/bbpress/form-forum.php`	This template is used to display the **Create new forum** form, if the user have privileges to do so.
`/bbpress/form-protected.php`	This template is used to display the **Protected** topic form.
`/bbpress/form-reply.php`	This template is used to display the form used for topic replies.
`/bbpress/form-topic-merge.php`	This template is used to display the form used for topic merges.
`/bbpress/form-topic-split.php`	This template is used to display the form used for splitting topics.
`/bbpress/form-topic-tag.php`	This template is used to display the form used to allow users to add tags.
`/bbpress/form-topic.php`	This template is used to display the new topic form.
`/bbpress/form-user-edit.php`	This template is used to display the **Edit user** form.
`/bbpress/form-user-login.php`	This template is used to display the login form, which is used in sidebars.
`/bbpress/form-user-lost-pass.php`	This template is used to display the "Lost Password" form.
`/bbpress/form-user-register.php`	This template is used to display the "Register" form.
`/bbpress/form-user-roles.php`	This template is used to display the form used to assign user roles.

- **Loop templates**: Loops are mainly used to display lists of forums, topics, and replies. The following is a list of loop templates:

Filename	Function
`/bbpress/loop-forums.php`	This template provides the loop used to display a list of forums.
`/bbpress/loop-replies.php`	This template provides the loop used to display a list of replies.
`/bbpress/loop-single-forum.php`	This template provides the loop used to display a list of topics in a single forum.
`/bbpress/loop-single-reply.php`	This template provides the loop used to display a single reply using the `[bbp-single-reply]` shortcode.
`/bbpress/loop-single-topic.php`	This template provides the loop used to display a single topic using the `[bbp-single-topic id=$topic_id]` shortcode.
`/bbpress/loop-topics.php`	This template provides the loop used for a list of topics.

- **Pagination templates**: These templates are used to handle pagination, which is the process of splitting up data over multiple pages. The following is a list of pagination templates:

Filename	Function
`/bbpress/pagination-replies.php`	This template handles the pagination of replies (if there is more than one page of replies, this template splits them up).
`/bbpress/pagination-topics.php`	This template handles the pagination of topics.

- **Miscellaneous templates**: These templates don't fit into any of the previous categories.

Filename	Function
`bbpress-functions.php`	This template loads functions purely designed to run with bbPress. You shouldn't delete anything in this file, as it handles the default structure; so if any file is missing, this file tells bbPress what to look for and how to display the new file. However, if you are careful, you can add functions at the bottom of this file, which will only be loaded when a bbPress page is displayed. This is handy if you have a large website and want to increase the loading speed.

As you can see, there are a lot of templates used to display bbPress data. Many of them are intertwined, but how can we use these to make changes? I'm going to talk you through two simple examples on how to edit the forums templates to display more information.

Adding the Recent Topics section beneath the home page

In bbPress Version 1.x, the home page of the forums had, at the bottom, a list of recent topics. This was removed in bbPress Version 2.x, but you can mimic this functionality if you want to.

To do so, open up the `/bbpress/content-archive-forum.php` file located in your theme and locate the following lines:

```
<?php if ( bbp_has_forums() ) : ?>
<?php bbp_get_template_part( 'loop',     'forums'    ); ?>
<?php else : ?>
```

Change these lines to the following:

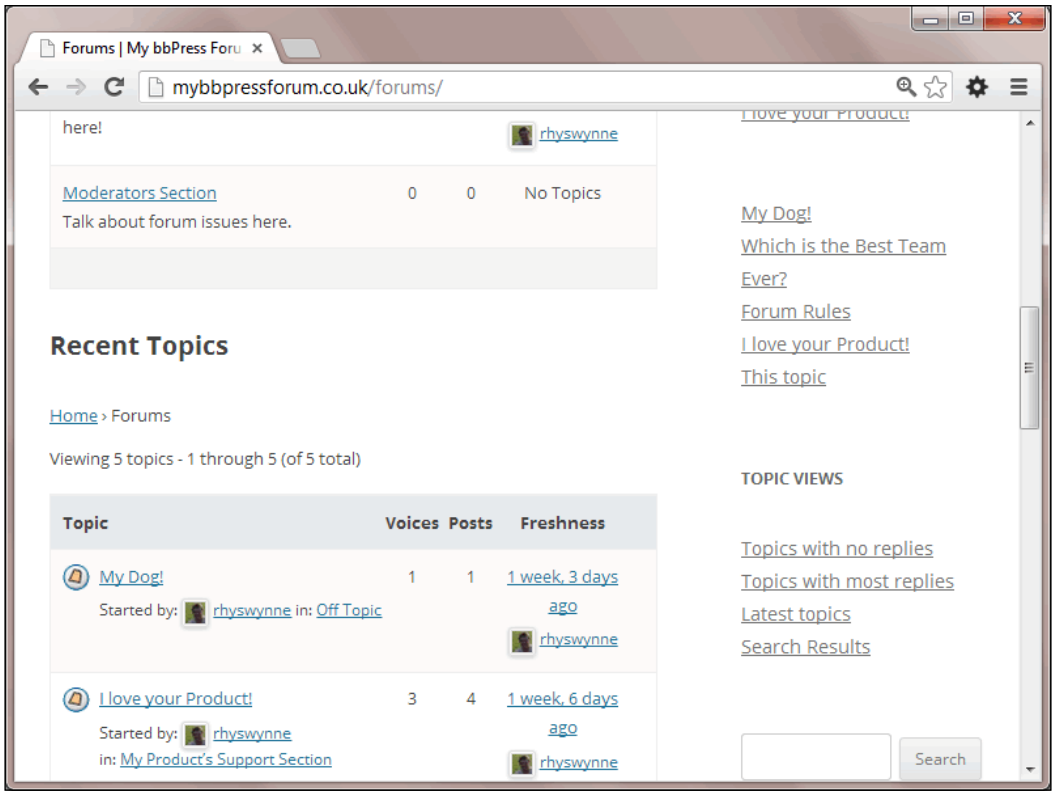
```
<?php if ( bbp_has_forums() ) : ?>
<?php bbp_get_template_part( 'loop',     'forums'    ); ?>
<?php if ( bbp_has_topics() ) { ?>
    <h2><?php _e('Recent Topics','bbpress'); ?></h2>
    <?php bbp_get_template_part( 'bbpress/content', 'archive-topic' );
?>
<?php } ?>
<?php else : ?>
```

Save and upload the file to your server.

What this code does is it first checks if there are any topics located in the forum with the `if ( bbp_has_topics() )` call. If so, it displays the `bbpress/content-archive-topic.php` template part, which is designed to display an archive of the topics (the `bbp_get_template_part( 'bbpress/content', 'archive-topic' );` line). The section will have a header **Recent Topics**, wrapped in an `<h2>` HTML tag (the `<h2><?php _e('Recent Topics','bbpress'); ?></h2>` line).

> If you have been using HTML for any length of time, you may have wondered why `<h2>Recent Topics</h2>` wasn't used. By using WordPress `_e` function to display text, you are telling WordPress that it is a display string. This will allow ease of translation should you ever wish to change the language of your site or deploy the template on a site in another language.

Open up your bbPress forum; you should see a list of recent topics beneath the forum list:



Adding a Return To The Forum link on a user's profile page

One small usability issue I've noticed when designing bbPress templates in the past has been the user's profile page: there is rarely an easy way back to your forum from the user's page. I like to add a **Return To The Forum** link at the bottom of the user's page so that users can return to the forum's home page after viewing a user's details.

To achieve this, open up the `bbpress/user-details.php` file within your theme. Towards the end, you should see the following lines of code:

```
</ul>
</div><!-- #bbp-user-navigation -->
</div><!-- #bbp-single-user-details -->
<?php do_action( 'bbp_template_after_user_details' ); ?>
```

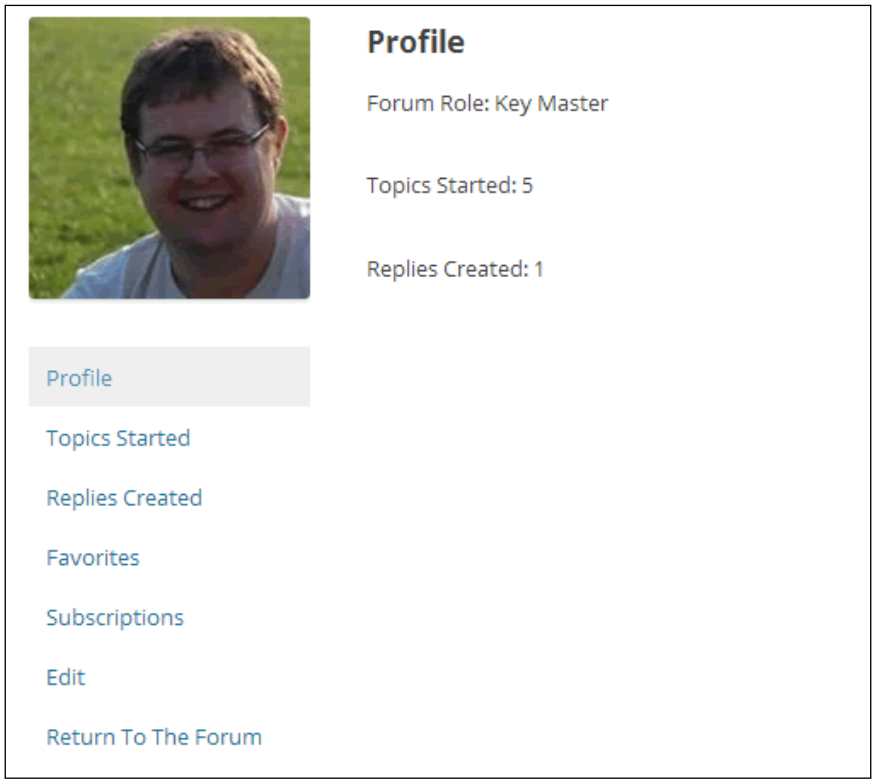
Immediately above the `</ul>` tag, add the following lines of highlighted code. The end of the file looks something similar to this:

```
    <li>
      <span class="bbp-user-edit-link">
      <a href=" <?php echo home_url('/forums/'); ?> " title="<?php
_e( 'Return To The Forum', 'bbpress' ); ?>"><?php _e( 'Return To The
Forum', 'bbpress' ); ?></a>
      </span>
    </li>
  </ul>
</div><!-- #bbp-user-navigation -->
</div><!-- #bbp-single-user-details -->
<?php do_action( 'bbp_template_after_user_details' ); ?>
```

This code adds a list item to the unordered list. The item is styled using a `<span>` element of the `bbp-user-edit-link` class. The link element uses the WordPress function `home_url` to get the URL of the home page of your website. As we want the forum home URL, we add a variable of `/forums/` so that the URL for the link is `http://www.mybbpressdomain.com/forums/`. The link has an anchor text and the title **Return To The Forum**.

Please note that this code will only work if you haven't changed the URL slug of the forums home page. If you have, replace `/forums/` in `home_url` with whatever your URL slug is.

Save and upload and head to a profile page. You should see a **Return To The Forum** link at the bottom of a profile, such as the one in the following screenshot:



Integrating bbPress functionality into WordPress with shortcodes

bbPress, like many other plugins, adds shortcodes to WordPress. Shortcodes are small one- or two-word phrases or codes that tell WordPress to replace the code with some other functionality. It is very similar in structure to BBCode; so, for example, the BBCode for bold text is `[b]Bold[/b]`.

You can give any function a shortcode, and it is useful for displaying rich data within posts or pages without having the security risk of placing code within posts or pages. bbPress allows you to create your own pages or posts within WordPress with bbPress functionality; so, for example, you can include forum replies within posts about threads. You can also use shortcodes to create more user friendly forms.

bbPress shortcode list

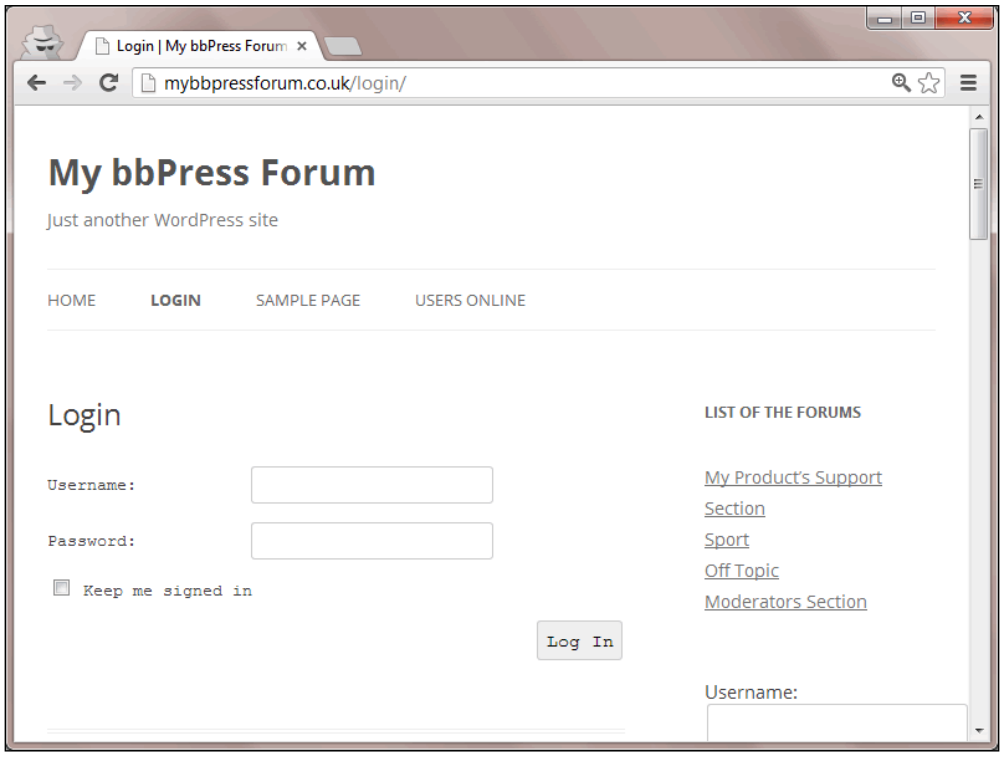
Shortcode	Function
`[bbp-forum-index]`	This shortcode displays all the forums, in a similar way to the index page. Use this code if you don't want to have `/forums/` as your forum home.
`[bbp-forum-form]`	This shortcode displays the **New Forum** form.
`[bbp-single-forum id=$forum_id]`	This shortcode displays a single forum and topics with an ID of `$forum_id`.
`[bbp-topic-index]`	This shortcode displays your last 15 topics, with pagination if required.
`[bbp-topic-form]`	This shortcode displays a **New Topic** form, with a dropdown to assign it to a particular forum.
`[bbp-single-topic id=$topic_id]`	This shortcode displays the topic and replies with the ID of `$topic_id`.
`[bbp-reply-form]`	This shortcode displays the **New Reply** form.
`[bbp-single-reply id=$reply_id]`	This shortcode displays a single reply with the ID of `$reply_id`.
`[bbp-topic-tags]`	This shortcode displays a cloud of all the tags on your site.
`[bbp-single-tag id=$tag_id]`	This shortcode displays a list of topics associated with the tag of ID `$tag_id`.
`[bbp-single-view]`	This shortcode displays the topics associated with a single view.
`[bbp-search]`	This shortcode displays the search input form template.
`[bbp-search-form]`	This shortcode displays the search form template.
`[bbp-login]`	This shortcode displays the login form template.
`[bbp-register]`	This shortcode displays the registration form template.
`[bbp-lost-pass]`	This shortcode displays the **Lost Password** form template.
`[bbp-stats]`	This shortcode displays the forum statistics.

Again, if you have used WordPress for any length of time, you should be familiar with shortcodes; but if you have not, we'll go through a tutorial to help you create more user friendly registration forms and integrate them with your bbPress template.

Creating more user friendly login forms with shortcodes

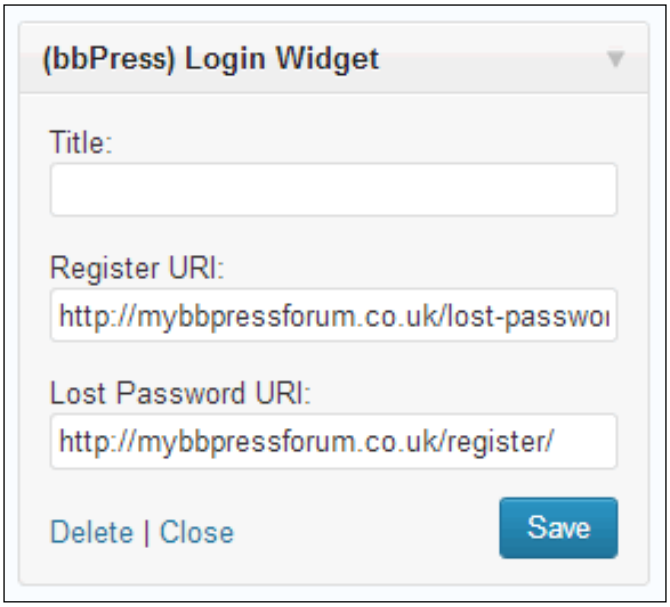
Earlier in this chapter, we created a widget that allowed the user to log in from the sidebar. We added two URLs for the **Register** and **Lost Password?** pages. While those pages were perfectly adequate, to aid user friendliness, we can style the **Lost Password?** and **Register** pages in a similar way to the rest of the site. This does require the creation of a few pages though.

From the Dashboard page in WordPress Administration, click on the **Add New** submenu item located under the **Pages** menu item. Entitle the page `Login` and then in the main content box, simply put `[bbp-login]` and publish the page. Log out of WordPress and visit the page in question. You should see a page that looks something similar to this:



Log in again and create a page called **Register**, with `[bbp-register]` in the page content, and a page called **Lost Password?**, with `[bbp-lost-pass]` in the page content. Publish both these pages and make sure they work. You should see similar pages to the one in the preceding screenshot, with slightly different forms.

Note down the URLs of both the pages and return to the widget screen. Find any login widget and replace the default WordPress **Lost Password URI** with the URL to the **Lost Password?** page and the default WordPress **Register URI** with the URL to the **Register** we recently created.

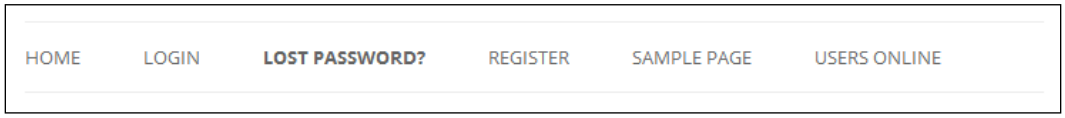


Now return to your forum and log out. Find your (bbPress) **Login Widget** and click on either the **Register URI** or **Lost Password URI** link rather than seeing the WordPress-branded pages for either; you should see your blog's pages with the forms embedded in it.

For ease, we have created very simple pages. You can go back and add content to any of the pages discussed previously. I recommend adding either a link, or displaying the forum's ground rules or terms and conditions on the **Register** page.

Adding your forum to navigation areas using custom menus

If you are new to WordPress, or developing a site as you read this book, you may have noticed towards the conclusion of the previous chapter that as you created each individual page, it was added to the navigation menu.



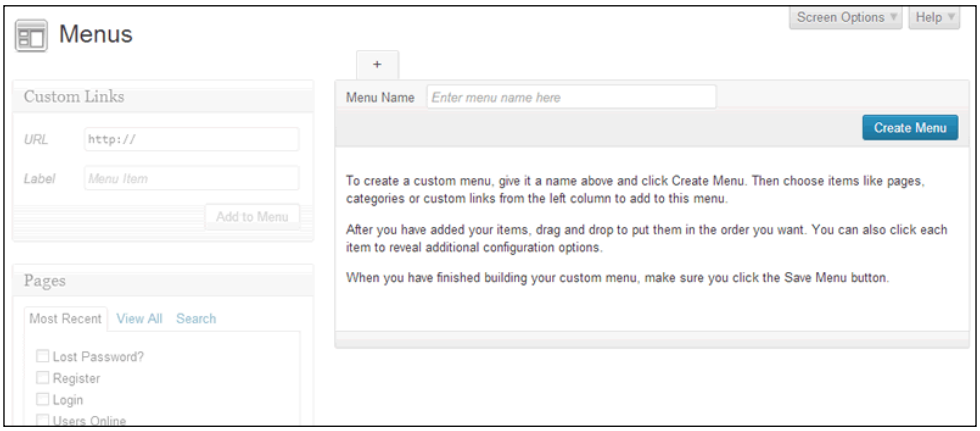
This is because WordPress, by default, creates a navigation menu with the names of all pages. As sites grow, this area can become very cluttered and you may not want all pages to be displayed.

Luckily, you can easily prevent this by using custom menus.

Custom menus are a WordPress feature that allow users to easily create menus without knowing anything about coding. While not strictly a bbPress function, it can be useful for forum owners to know how to create and manage one.

Creating a custom menu and adding links to your bbPress forums

To begin adding your custom menu, from the WordPress Administration Dashboard, click on **Menus**, which is a submenu item underneath the **Appearance** menu item. You should be greeted with a screen similar to the following:

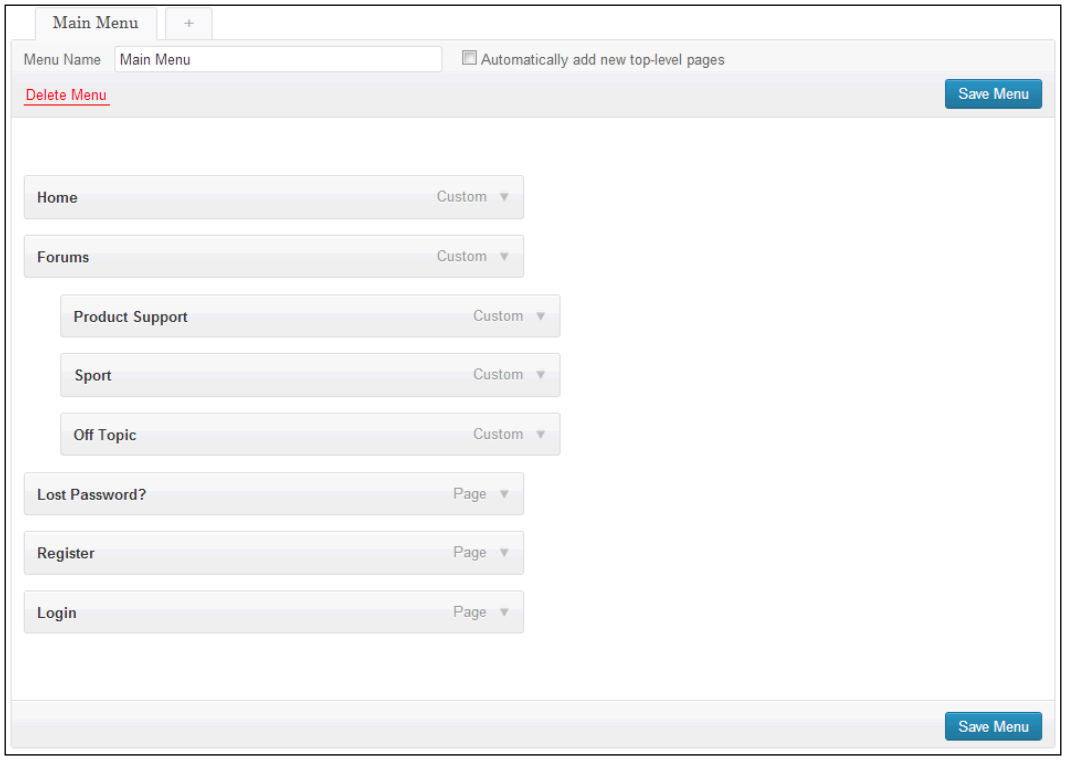


Click on the **Menu Name** box to give your menu a name and then click on **Create Menu** to create a new menu.

Unfortunately, bbPress doesn't have the easiest method of adding menu items, like you can add WordPress pages or categories, so they need to be added to the **Custom Links window**. Get the URL of any forum you want to add to the menu and add it to the **URL** field in the **Custom Links** box. The **Label** field is the link you click on to access that menu, so give it a descriptive name. Click on **Add To Menu** to add it to the menu.

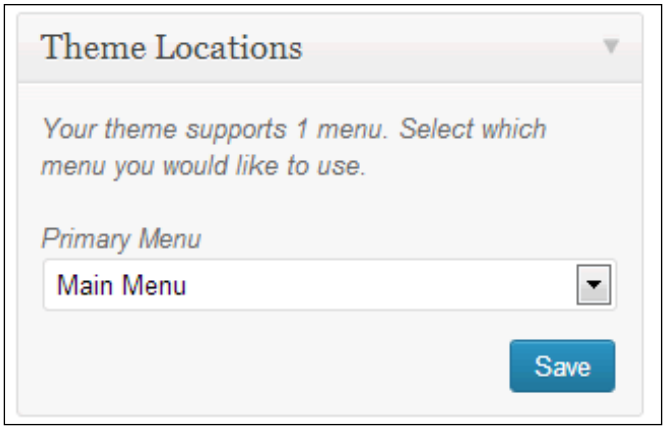
A box with your label name should appear on the right-hand side of the screen. You can then drag it to reposition it in the menu, or drag left-to-right to reposition it as a submenu of another menu.

After creating and reordering a number of menu items, you should have a menu that looks like the following screenshot:



Click on **Save Menu** to save the menu.

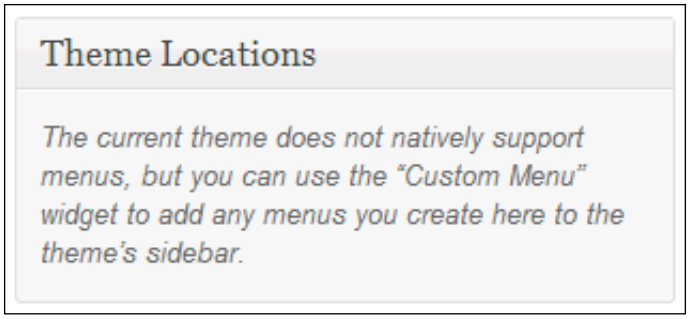
Towards the left-hand side of the screen, there should be a drop-down box entitled **Theme Locations**. These are usually (one or more) sections in a theme, where you can select which menu is displayed.



Select in the drop-down menu, which menu you wish to display and click on **Save**; then return to your site's home page. You should see the menu you have just created prominently on the page.

Adding an area for custom menus in WordPress

Most themes do have an area already built in that displays custom menus. However, if you have a WordPress site that isn't coded to high standards, or you have an old theme, you may see the following message when you try to add your menu to a theme:



In short, the issue here is that your theme doesn't have any areas to add menus. Luckily, you can easily fix this with two lines of code.

Open up your theme's `functions.php` file and add the following line of code at the bottom:

```
register_nav_menu( 'primary', __( 'Primary Menu', 'bbpress' ) );
```

This line of code tells WordPress to register a navigational menu with the name `primary` and the display name **Primary Menu**. Upload the changed `functions.php` file and refresh the page; you should be able to select any menu to be assigned as the **Primary Menu** of that page.

While you can assign any menu as the Primary Menu, it won't be displayed anywhere on your site yet.

To do this, you will need to add the following line of code somewhere on your page. Unfortunately, due to the nature of themes, I cannot say exactly where as every theme will be different, but my advice would be trial and error. A great place to start would be your WordPress theme's `header.php` file.

```
<?php wp_nav_menu(); ?>
```

The `wp_nav_menu` function creates a new navigation menu. If you only have one navigation menu, this will work. Alternatively, you may need to use some of the extended arrays. A full guide on using this function is available at `http://codex.wordpress.org/Function_Reference/wp_nav_menu`.

Creating a forum-only widget sidebar

If you have visited a number of forums, you will notice that forums generally have a sidebar area that stays static compared to the rest of the site. With WordPress's templating system, it is quite straightforward to create a sidebar widget area that is separate from the rest of the site.

Registering the widget area

First of all, we need to register the sidebar. Open up your theme's `functions.php` file and place the following code at the bottom:

```
function mybbpressforum_widgets_init() {
  register_sidebar( array(
    'name' => __( 'Forum Sidebar', 'bbpress' ),
    'id' => 'sidebar-forum',
    'before_widget' => '<aside id="%1$s" class="widget %2$s">',
```

```
        'after_widget' => '</aside>',
        'before_title' => '<h3 class="widget-title">',
        'after_title' => '</h3>',
      ) );

    }
    add_action( 'widgets_init', 'mybbpressforum_widgets_init' );
```

This creates a function called `mybbpressforum_widgets_init()`. The function then, using the command `register_sidebar`, registers a widget area. Its options are passed in an `array()` function. The following is a list of available options:

- `name`: This is the display name of the widget area (in this case, **Forum Sidebar**). This is the name that the user sees in the **Widget** area of the site.
- `Id`: This is the name of the WordPress sidebar. You use the ID to display the sidebar on the site (more of that later). In our example, we've named the sidebar **sidebar-forum**.
- `before_widget` and `after_widget`: Both of them define what style each widget is wrapped around. This helps styling as you can define the IDs and the class each widget has.
- `before_title` and `after_title`: Both of them define the code the title of each widget is wrapped around. In our example, we will have widgets wrapped with `<h3 class="widget-title">Title of the Widget</h3>`. Again, this helps in styling the widgets.

Upload your modified `functions.php` file to your site, and visit the **Widgets** page in the **Dashboard** page of WordPress Administration. You should now see the **Forum Sidebar** displayed on the right hand side of the screen.

While you can add widgets to the **Forum Sidebar**, the sidebar will not be displayed as you haven't created the custom sidebar template yet.

Creating a forum sidebar template

To create a custom sidebar template, make a copy of the `sidebar.php` file within your theme. The copy should be named `sidebar-forum.php` and saved in the same location as `sidebar.php`.

Open `sidebar-forum.php` and look for any mention of the `dynamic_sidebar` function. When found, change the function `dynamic_sidebar` to the following:

```
dynamic_sidebar('sidebar-forum');
```

The `dynamic_sidebar` function tells WordPress to display the sidebar with the sidebar name given in brackets. As we have defined our forum sidebar with the name `sidebar-forum` earlier on in this chapter, we tell WordPress to use this sidebar whenever `sidebar-forum.php` is displayed. The only issue at the moment is that the `sidebar-forum.php` file is not being used anywhere in your theme.

Adding the custom sidebar template to your forum template

To integrate `sidebar-forum.php` in your template, you need to open every template file that your forum uses. As defined earlier in the chapter, they are the following:

- `forum.php`
- `forums.php`
- `bbpress.php`

If you don't have any of these files, make a copy of your theme's `page.php` file (or if there isn't a `page.php` file, make a copy of `index.php`), call it `forum.php`, and look for the following line of code:

```
<?php get_sidebar(); ?>
```

This WordPress function calls any sidebar; by default, `sidebar.php`. However, we can define the sidebar called by changing the line to the following:

```
<?php get_sidebar('forum'); ?>
```

This function displays the sidebar, `sidebar-forum.php`. By changing the name between the brackets, you can have any name you wish for the file (with the **sidebar** prefix).

Upload the `sidebar-forum.php` and `forum.php` files to your site and visit your home page before visiting your forum pages. You should see a different sidebar on each of these pages.

Summary

You should now have a forum integrated within your site. Now is the time that you can focus on the most important aspect of building a forum: building a community around it. This is the hardest aspect, as building a community around your website is not something you can learn in a book. However, by making connections, working hard, and thinking creatively, you can help your forum grow into something remarkable.

bbPress is an aid to help you grow. As you're now familiar with bbPress, you can manage your forum effectively, add on features with plugins to make it attractive, and integrate it with your site using themes. You should also be in a position where you can set up forums in bbPress for your colleagues and hopefully train them to manage the forum well.

If you get stuck, remember you're part of two larger communities now: bbPress and WordPress. Both communities are among the most helpful and supportive communities I've ever been a part of. They are forward-thinking (at the time of writing this book, bbPress Version 2.3 had just been released), and are helpful in a way that only the open source community can be. Reach out to people, show off your site, and make friends, because you are just beginning your journey with open source software. My genuine hope is that you continue it for as long as possible, as through it I've made a living and made friends doing so.

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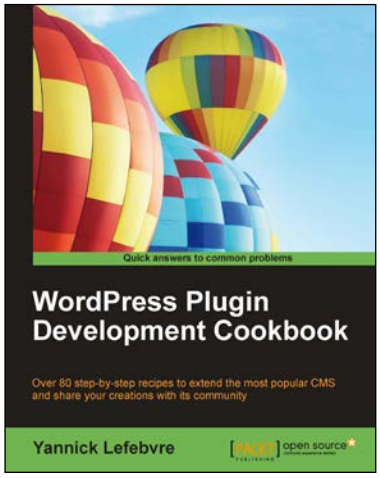

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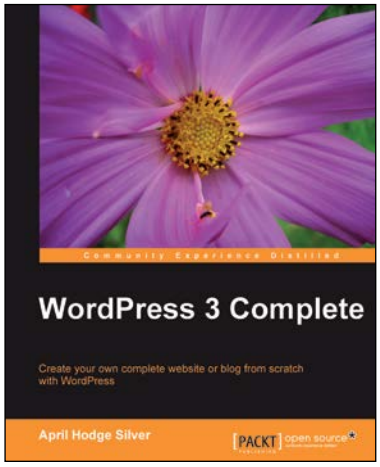

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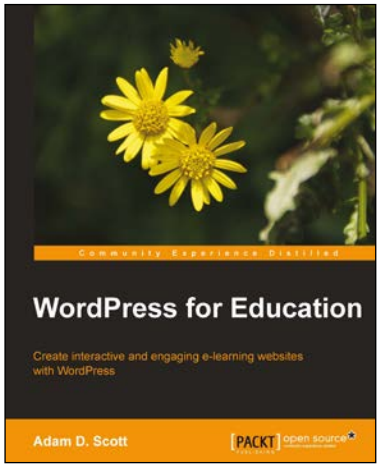

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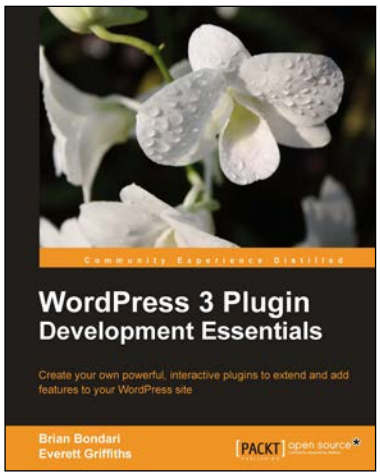

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